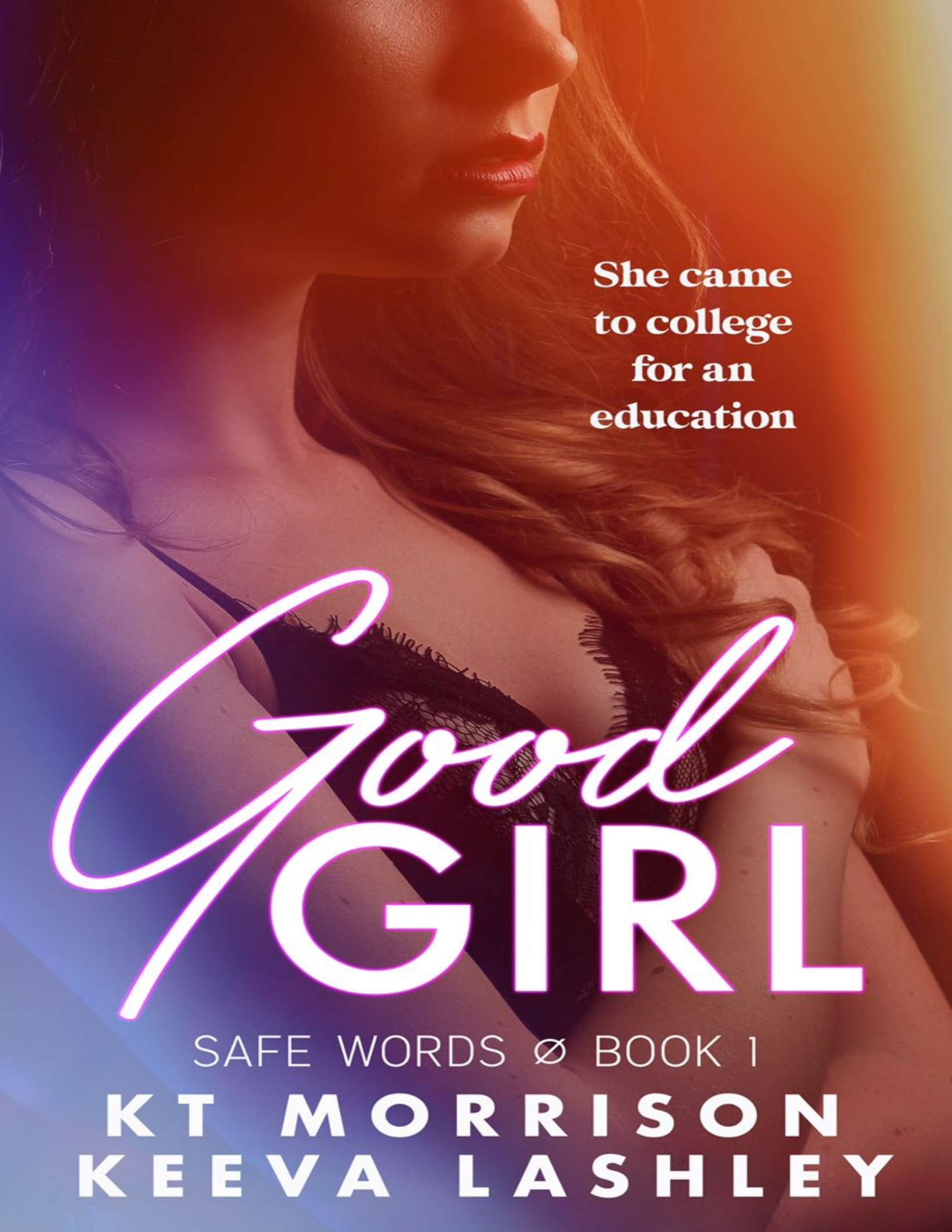




She came
to college
for an
education

Good GIRL

SAFE WORDS Ø BOOK 1

KT MORRISON
KEEVA LASHLEY

good girl

Safe Words

Book One

kt morrison

keeva lashley

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about the author

KT Morrison writes complicated and kinky love stories.

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

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GOOD GIRL

Safe Words // Book 1

38,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

1

so low

RUNNING THE CAMPUS'S RED CLAY TRACK AT NIGHT ALWAYS FELT familiar. So far from rural Illinois, but repeating sprints in the cold under the buzz of sodium lights, you could be anywhere. Even back home.

Ancient stone frontages of the college halls faced her, looking down, winking their warm light as she crouched in a three-point stance. Bodies moved in those square yellow spaces, students getting ready to explode out on a Friday night after a long week of classes and obligations.

Launched out of the stance, she hurtled the track, the tap-tap-tap of her spikes on the gravel coming back at her off the cold grey granite. 200 meters after 200 meters, again and again.

Even out in that frigid, fragile air, her track jacket thrown to the side in the frosted grass, sweat chilled on her skin.

Crisp, fragile night, all the stars out. Indigo blue. Black twisted November branches reaching up to scratch the starlit sky. Each breath a roiling cumulus cloud, droplets falling with dread. Chest heaving, pushing herself to her limit. Beyond her limit. Sprint after sprint. Just not making the time.

Frustration. Breaths becoming whimpers. Falling to her knees. Gravel in her skin . . .

ALL THE BATHROOM DOORS HAD AN 'E' on them. Depending on the floor's residents's vote that year the 'E' was swiveled to reflect: an upright 'E' shaped a 'W' for Women, 'E' turned once clockwise was 'M' for Men, a plain 'E' was for Everyone. And If the 'E' pointed with the prongs to the left, looking like the number three, it meant three people: Me, myself, and I. Solo. That's where she was now. The place for when you wanted to be alone.

Hot water splashed her back, easing away the nighttime chill. An ache worked in her knees from running in the cold. Her low back was tight, the muscles in her thighs and calves felt like they'd snapped and rolled like shutters into wound balls under her skin; hard iron knots running up the back of both legs. She sat under the shower's weak sprinkle, on her ass on the small square tiles, hugging her knees, staring into the steamy blankness.

There was a dorm on the east side of campus, Emmett Hall, where the showers were all open. No dividers, just spigots sticking out of the tile every three feet. It used to be the boys's college back when the campus was segregated by gender a half century ago. The residents of Emmett voted it co-ed this year—boys and girls all congregating naked in a wide open bathroom—and she couldn't imagine having to humiliate herself every day, washing up in full view of all the other students. India told her they sometimes did sing-alongs if it felt uncomfortable. The whole idea was just so crazy.

At the start of the year she'd voted okay to coed bathrooms for her floor in Rothschild Hall. The vote was assured to be anonymous, but she feared she'd be the only holdout—it took only one vote to disallow—and everyone would *know* it was her. The shy one. The mousy one. So she voted yes. But after almost daily complaints from her boyfriend Brian back home in

Illinois, she relented, and now had to walk down the stairs every time she wanted a shower or even just to pee, trying to keep him happy. They weren't even going out anymore, at least not officially. *No, damn it, officially.*

The stress mounted every day here and now she buried her face in her wet hands, rubbing her cheeks and growling softly in the hissing shower stall.

Since coming to Morrison College, her 200 meter times got slower. In high school she was the fastest girl the Hager Hill Hawks had. The school website said so, putting up the picture of college-bound young prospect, Angel Parker. Fresh-faced and strawberry haired, she hated every single one of those images. They always caught her after a run, hair tied back in a tangled tail, pale cheeks blushed with a cherry broadcast, any blemish on her skin amplified like a red dot lighthouse beacon. Now she was one of a dozen fast girls on the Morrison track team, all of them top runners from their own high schools. And while she'd shown strong in late-August and September, October took its toll. Classes, dorm life, and the effort it took to avoid dorm life, all worked against her. Dorm food was awful and finding good sleep in the churning new-adult ant hill of Rothschild Hall was impossible. The more those microseconds slowed her sprinting, the more the oppression squeezed at her. The more the oppression squeezed, the more the bad thoughts came in like slippery silverfish working through the flaky rot festering under the floorboards.

She scratched at her neck, turned the crown of her head up to the spray, desperate now to find any way out of tonight.

The decision to 'party' with her roommate India was made at a time of momentary elation and arrived with her mother's prompting to "*Go out and have fun like a normal college woman.*" Only, it was a few days ago she agreed to go out with India and her friends, and now the actual *moment* was

upon her, and the idea she wouldn't burrow into her bed and read a book while the dorm got quiet on a Friday night, everyone out drinking and whooping it up, was terrifying.

From outside the shower, a knock came on the outer door to the hall.

India's voice on the other side of the metal: "Hey—you in there?"

Her mournful growling turned to a groan. Her hand searched around above her head for the shower's lever, pulled it down to shut off the water. Now it was quiet but for the drips.

Toward the door, she raised her voice, "Yeah?"

"Angel?"

She said yeah again, then could hear India talking to someone else in the hall. Arms hugged around her shins, she plopped her chin between slippery knees and waited.

At last, India's attention returned. "Angel, baby . . .?"

"Yeah?"

"Are you ready yet?—We gotta go soon, I'm supposed to meet Kimball . . ."

"Almost ready."

"Hurry, baby," India said, her voice retracting from the door as she went back down the hall to the stairwell, returning to the dorm room they shared.

It was quiet again, the silence like a weight on her back.

IN THE HALL outside the dorm room, she texted Mom to affirm that her daughter was going out tonight and wasn't backing out. Some good in this had to be found, and if it was only assuring Mom her eldest daughter was normal, it would have to do. Before she slipped the phone back in her skirt pocket, her mother dinged her back.

Karen: so proud of you! 🎉 🥳

She grunted, grimaced, put the phone back in her skirt pocket.

Her track clothing and toiletries were bundled in her gym bag, and she'd dressed for the party in the solo bathroom: black skirt, black leggings, black loafers, black and blue plaid button down, black sweater. All fitting tonight's black theme.

Deep breath taken, she stepped into her room, glad to find none of the other girls were there yet.

Only India was there, sitting on her dorm room bed, not even dressed yet.

India sat next to the open window, frigid air clawing their heat out into the quad. There was a joint in a small ashtray on the table next to India's bed and she was sitting, chin perched on a knee as she repainted her toenails with another layer of clear-coat. Still in shorts, still in a baggy T-shirt. At least her hair and makeup were done.

India's long caramel legs gleamed in a way Angel coveted. Skinny knees, shapely calves; India was the kind of girl she endlessly envied. Rich, effortless, confident, stunning; commanding attention and respect without a seeming effort. India's last name was King, and she was the grand daughter of the late Morris King, quiet co-lead singer of the Commanders, the Sixties Motown soul singers. India was from L.A.; Beverly Hills specifically. Her grandfather had writing royalties on a half dozen classic hits and did one solo album in the early eighties before he died of cancer. On that album was

the song “Only Loving You,” and it was Mom and Dad’s wedding song; on move-in day back in August, Mom discovered India was related to Morris and gushed and babbled how great Morris was and how much that song meant to her and how it was her wedding song and how she danced with Dad that night, talking non-stop till her eyes got all shiny. There wasn’t an imaginary hole deep enough for Angel to bury herself in, starting off college with that kind of embarrassment permanently cemented. India had smiled and was gracious in a way that made Angel feel like this wasn’t the first middle-aged white lady to try conveying the deep and complex personal meaning of her grandfather’s work. And when Angel’d chastised Mom later that night when they went out together to the diner in town—her own eyes getting shiny—Mom had passed it off, saying it was no big deal and she was making too much of it, getting mad. Yeah, sure, except Mom and Dad were back on the plane back to Illinois that night and she was the weird girl with the midwestern mom who cried to her daughter’s roommate standing there in a barn coat and flannel shirt and smelling faintly of farm animals when almost every other girl here had moms and dads who looked like they were catalog models.

“Why’s that?” India asked.

Angel said, “Why’s what . . .?” But a hollow voice rose to answer from India’s phone, tossed on the bedsheets beside her. She was talking to someone else.

Whatever it was, it was funny, and their voices laughed together. Angel sat down hard between the books littering her bed, making them jump, leaned her tangled half-dry mess of a hairdo against the stone wall. She’d rushed getting ready and here was India, not even dressed yet. She picked up a dog-eared copy of Wharton’s Old New York novellas for 117S Literature & Interpretation and pretended to read.

It sounded like India said *I thought it would be cheaper if we bought an eight-ball*. Whatever—she didn't want to know.

Her eyes moved to the window sill—no, were *drawn* to the windowsill. There on the ledge sat a small but foreboding package. A ribbon wrapped box that arrived in a bubble wrap paper envelope. And she'd convinced herself it was a *jewelry* box; she feared the significance of what might be within. That was why it remained unopened after sitting there since it arrived in the mail on Tuesday. She'd been ignoring the texts from Brian that she knew were fishing to learn whether she'd opened it or not. There must be a tracking number that told him it'd been delivered to her on campus, but he hadn't mentioned it directly. So she wouldn't either.

India rose now, stretched, came between the beds to lean a knee on Angel's mattress. "You ready to have some fun?"

"Sure," she said, trying to be positive, but hearing her answer aloud, playing it back in her head, it did not sound like something a fun-loving, confident young—and normal—girl said. The word sounded like a tangled ball of nerves.

India laughed, batted Angel's loafer and slunk off the bed, turning, backhand-ruffling out her long mane of toffee and honey hair that hung heavy in tight ringlets. She undressed in front of her, and Angel was used to it by now, averting her eyes but still registering her roommate's physical perfection. Hating it and wanting it at the same time. It just intimidated her, got her chewing the inside of her cheek while India put a dress over her head and let it slip down her body, see-sawing her hips, tugging at the dress's skirt to get the black fabric to settle against her perfectly. She stooped, grabbed the still-smoking joint, puffed, put it out, turned, presented herself, then exhaled the smoke from her nostrils. "What do you think?"

India looked like a movie star. Their dorm room was strung with small fairy lights that twinkled. Only the table lamp was on, and in the dim but warm light all she could make out was India's slinky silhouette. Makeup was slight but dark and smoky; she wore earrings that looked like diamonds; her dress was designer for sure, the way it was tailored and stuck to her body.

Angel scooted forward, put her feet on the floor, made an eye-rolling expression of wonder. A submissive and pandering move under her roommate's superior charm and beauty. "What shoes are you going to wear?"

India winked and smiled, bouncing on her toes, prompting a blast of happy juice from Angel's brain—like she'd asked the right question. The feeling was like scoring a goal, like you were getting the hang of something, like maybe being social with people was something within her grasp. Then India was off to the corner of her room where her many shoes lay in a mismatched hillock—sneakers, sandals, flip flops, pumps—shoving a foot into a low black heel with a red sole.

It seemed as though India arrived on campus already in motion. When Angel arrived with her mom and dad, India was already in, room decorated, already on the phone making plans for the coming weekend; strange students, boys and girls, popping their head in to the room to see what India was up to, if she wanted to go do something. It was like India'd been at Morrison for years, not just a few hours before Angel. Those strings of white lights dangling over India's bed and high along the line of their ceiling were disallowed, clearly stated in the resident prep package to be an absolute fire hazard no-no. India took them down an hour before a young guy from the Fire Department checked all the rooms. As he left, wolf-whistles following behind him from some girls, India was already stringing them back up. Angel couldn't have found a more unlike roommate, yet she didn't want another roommate. As intimidating as India was, there was a

certain fascination in getting a front-row seat to how a popular girl thought and operated. Sometimes she caught herself studying India and her friends silently, like some researcher in the wild making field notes, learning the minutiae of their communication, looking for subtext, references, motivations . . .

It probably made her look weirder to them, but maybe some day she'd come out of her shell, and it would be nice to know the language.

India turned now, having located the matching shoe in the heap and slipping it on, swishing out her hair again and posing fully dressed. Toes pointed, long and lean, skin gleaming and unblemished. She smiled then gave a sly, fierce look that made Angel's eyebrows wriggle. "You look—"

"Look at *this* bitch," a voice said from their doorway.

India pivoted and posed, one leg out and flexing, knowing already she was on camera somehow, her friend Jasmine coming in iPhone first, camera running. Behind her in an ambling file were Charlie, Abby, and Beck, all texting.

Jasmine walked a semicircle around India, coming between the beds, India working it, posing, hair tossing, generally gregarious and compelling in a way that was hard to ignore.

Charlie, Abby, and Beck engaged now too, all the girls in a shrill clutch, hugging, admiring, Jasmine and India checking out the video replay on Jasmine's phone.

Charlie turned Angel's way, gave a chin-nod in silent greeting, eyebrows lowering as she registered Angel's similar all-black attire. "Hey—what, you're coming too?"

2

party bus

SIX GIRLS DRESSED ALL IN BLACK WALKED OVER TO HARRIS HALL AND met Kimball, who was already lit up.

Kimball waited for them—or India, really—leaning against a tree trunk in the dark, then moseying out to intercept them on the walkway that cut through the heart of the Quad, the square park posted between the three biggest and oldest dorm halls on campus. Kimball was all in black too, of course, except for his frat’s red and white striped scarf.

“You look like a bunch of women up to no good,” he said in a laconic drawl that was one-hundred percent contrived. He held arms out to receive India, and they kissed cheeks.

India had a crush on Kimball and Kimball had the hots for India, but the two hadn’t done anything together (India swore), even though they’d spent two months the last year of high school together, meeting by chance at some international school program in Rome. Kimball was super-preppy-white, and from the northeast, India a multi-racial Hollywood hippy-type, but they had similar qualities they recognized in each other. They worked well as good friends.

“Good evening, ladies,” Kimball said now, grabbing hands and kissing cheeks, knowing who all the other girls were, getting to Angel who was hiding out at the back of the pack, satisfied for Kimball to pass her by without notice. But he got her, smiling, cocking his head, saying, “Who’s this one, India?” He took both her hands.

“You know Angel—she’s my roomie.” India sidled along Kimball, putting an arm around him. “She’s partying with us tonight.”

“Alright,” he drawled, eyes lazy, breath stinking of alcohol, “country girl all dressed up.” His gaze went up and down her, expression a drama class exercise in lusty appreciation, then Angel was forgotten, her hands released, and he was hooking an arm under India’s and leading them all out of the Quad and toward the campus’s main road.

Morrison got rid of the Greek scene a long time ago, but there were still frats off campus. The parties off-campus were all-welcome but tickets weren’t cheap. Last year Kimball’s frat hosted a White Party, where everyone admitted had to be wearing white, and even though it was off campus, admin published a complaint in the Herald. The party wasn’t canceled, but there was a noted rejection to its name. So this year the Chi guys were hosting the contrary Black Party at their frat house in the village. Same rules, different color.

Angel hung out at the back of the group as they walked out of the Quad’s park and toward the twinkling lights of the roundabout where Campus Road intersected Faculty Road, lamps reflecting off vehicles parked, traffic slipping along the divide between them and the old Hazlett Library beyond. She wished now she’d worn a coat, but her coat wasn’t black. Her coat was blue, and not a blue that could pass for a black in the dark, but a blue that would’ve wrecked her outfit and she feared would draw the ire of India’s friends. Instead, she shivered, admiring the girls as they walked ahead of

her, looking at their legs below the hems of their snazzy black coats that protected them from November in Vermont.

Jasmine, in her unzipped down parka, was complaining, voice shivering like she was cold, saying, “Where the hell did you park, Kimball? It’s freezing . . .”

India said, “Yeah, where’s your car?”

Kimball drove a BMW, and she’d been wondering how seven people were going to cram into it, and the liquor on Kimball’s breath had her concerned too, but thinking India would drive.

Kimball said, “My car? You think *I* can drive? I’ve been drinking since lunch.” He patted his breast; she assumed he had a hip flask or mickey in there.

Beck said, “Who’s coming to get us?”

Jasmine said, “You think I’m walking to the Chi house? . . .”

Kimball laughed. “*Walking?*—What kind of animal do you think I am?”

They emerged from the park near the curbside before it ran the roundabout’s circle, where there were cars lined along the curb, and traffic coming in and out. Kimball said, “I present to you, ladies, our Chi house chariot,” gesturing a hand to a black Sprinter van parked curbside. The windows were tinted, but it was lit from within and they could see it had leather couches and a small TV; the driver sat up front reading his phone.

India shook her head, laughed, said, “ATK—Always trust Kimball . . .”

IN THE BELLY of the party bus, everyone knew what to do with themselves except her, sitting on the bench with her side against the bump out that housed the bus's bathroom. Neon tubing ran in three shades of purple along the valence above the windows, shining funky light on them all. Music was cranked, and India, Kimball, and Jasmine talked in a close huddle; Charlie and Beck whispered into each other's ear and regaled; Abby stood in the centre of the bus's carpeted aisle, pouring from Kimball's flask into one of the limo's highball glasses liberated from the bar, which had been emptied of alcohol because no one here was of age in the state of Vermont. Careful not to spill, Abby still managed to dance in place, and Angel watched the muscles of her bare calves flex. Angel was the only one in leggings, but, seriously, it was November, and it was cold. She tugged at the hem of her skirt, moving it nearer her knee.

India's attitude toward drugs and alcohol was loose, and she left use to the weekend. She'd convinced this skinny senior with a thin mustache who lived over on the west side of campus to buy her bottles of vodka when she asked. The campus was divided by a main road that used to separate the boys' college from the girls' college. Morrison was two different colleges that became one back in the 1950s. All the performing arts buildings were on the west side of the road and it created a natural divide across the campus between the business-minded topsider crowd in the east and the quirky, tight-jean hipsters on the west.

Jasmine had separated herself from Kimball and India, who were taking turns whispering in ears. She read her phone with interest a moment, then said something to India, who shrugged.

With the music turned down from her phone, Jasmine asked them all, "Anyone hear of another party tonight, off campus?"

Charlie said there was one at the Bolshevik Bar on the main street and Jasmine said no, that wasn't it. Abby talked of two more, but Jasmine rejected them too. No one asked Angel, and that was fine.

Kimball said there was no better party than a Chi party anyway, and India wouldn't abandon him. India laughed, rested her cheek on his shoulder a moment.

Jasmine said, "Julia, black hair Julia from Emmett, she says there's some secret party out east."

Abby asked, "East *where*?" Still keeping her balance mid-ship, feet shoulder-width apart, hands holding out the flask and cup.

"East of Morrison."

Kimball asked whose party it was, his placid exterior cool heating up, and a look of chagrin tightening his stolid expression.

Angel noted India watching Kimball from his side and studying his reaction, India her own student of human behavior. Now she smiled, turning her face to Jasmine. "Tell me about this party, Jazzy . . ."

3

red stripes

IN THE DAYS LEADING UP TO THE CHI PARTY, ANGEL DIDN'T KNOW what to expect. Her great and dark fear was she would arrive to find steely young men and women lounging around with sexy sunken cheeks. Rich college girls with hazy heroin eyes, half-lidded, interspersed about a luxurious Persian rug in black lingerie with garters. Her entire sense of that part of social strata she'd been exempt from was brought to her via Netflix TV shows, HBO, commercials for expensive clothing, Instagram, well-lit music videos, ads in magazines . . .

Truth was, even though she was at a private northeastern college, an expensive one, surrounded by cool rich kids mostly, they were still all teenagers, as adult as they liked to pretend sometimes. In high school she'd avoided parties, but had been to a few. And despite the black attire, the Sprinter bus escort service, and the upper-class clientele, the party at the Chi house wasn't much different from what she'd seen at high school in Illinois.

The Chi house sat on a residential street tucked off Morrison village's Main Street. Just past the pizzeria, you turn right, three houses down and set back from the road, there was a house that was probably owned by some

Morrison mercantile baron a hundred-fifty years ago. But now it was the Chi house. A big clapboard white manse that could use a little care.

Out front there was a red and white flag one might mistake as an American flag, except there was no blue field with white stars. The trees in the front yard were strung with lights for Christmas, there were patio lanterns in the deep set wraparound porch. The porch had been decorated all in black. Black tables, black coolers, potted evergreen trees with twinkling Christmas lights and black ribbon woven through. Drinks were handed out from the coolers, but she declined at the door. The other girls and Kimball were eager, and Kimball escorted them past the two security guards who she recognized from the football team, India on his arm, Angel coming in last and expecting one of the football guys to put a hand out and reject her. *Sorry, you're not quite what this party is looking for.*

But then she was in, and the girls dispersed into the throng of black-dressed college kids. She hung close to India at first, but soon sank into the background, cocooned in droning sound, closed in by drunk revelers, surrounded yet somehow disregarded and ignored. Her roommate disappeared, and she didn't chase her down.

India had been kind to her since they were roomies. Sometimes she could be prickly, but mostly India seemed to have sympathy toward her awkward roommate. But at the party, India had other things to do. It wasn't just Kimball who wanted her attention. There were three other guys, and a multitude of girls happy to see her there. So Angel wandered, not knowing to do with her hands, sometimes putting them in the pockets of her skirt, other times checking her phone—everybody was *always* checking their phone. Then she sat on the couch; somebody spilled a drink on the arm and looked at her like it was her fault. She extricated herself from the front room, weaving through crowds of people while rap music boomed.

There were all the expected shenanigans: out back on the patio two shirtless guys in football helmets waged war head to head with pool noodles while the gathered crowd cheered them on. Party games were played, a group with a ping pong table playing beer pong, another table where a group drank as punishment playing a game based on the efforts made to construct a house of cards. Couples made out in corners, an argument broke out, and the two guys involved were hurried outside. She didn't follow to see if there was a fight, and soon everyone who'd gone out returned looking disappointed. A group of shy guys with red and white scarves who looked more her speed sat at a table playing cards. They had the energy where she figured she could slip in, spend the night sequestered and camped out, not getting bothered, but there were no seats available. And as nerdy as she, they'd also walled themselves off from the others with surly but nervous faces. At one point she ended up standing in a dim hallway by herself, leaning her back against the wall. Beck and Jasmine stood in the kitchen just by her shoulder talking shit about all the people they watched at the party. This girl Ashley such a fucking bitch, and that girl from so-and-so shouldn't even be at Morrison, so-and-so's parents were at resident check-in and they'd been drinking. She stood there, listening. Every person they named brought them closer to talking shit about Angel Parker. *Her parents are farmers . . . she's such a nerd . . . did you see her sitting on the party bus? Like, Jesus, have a drink and fucking loosen up . . . What's with that outfit? Like put on a dress or something, honey . . . Why did India even bring her? . . .* The two girls never mentioned her once, but just the fear of the potential to hear the truths of what they thought about Angel Parker had her retreating, going deeper into the darker heart of the frat house.

She ended up at a line for the bathroom. A guy and a girl came out together, everyone groaning, acting like the two of them were having sex in there. Maybe they were. . . . She tried to smile at them as they passed, show them a friendly face, but they ignored her.

When her turn came to enter the bathroom, she sat down on the toilet with her skirt and tights still on, just pretending to use the facility. It was a few minutes' break from the pressures of being seen at the party in full awkward display. A few minutes of rest and reprieve. She went through her phone, reread the last email from her dad about how he'd had to take down that old rotten oak tree all by himself, felling it all on his own without her to watch out for him but everything was okay, it came down about six feet away from the chicken coop and if he'd killed those chickens mom would've killed him. When she wasted too much time already, she flushed the toilet, pretended to wash her hands, then dipped out of the bathroom with her head down, avoiding eye contact.

"There she is," she heard from farther down the hall.

India and some other girl she didn't recognize stood at the end of the hall.

"Angel, come on, come here . . ."

She joined them, worried what they sought her for, but a certain glimpse at happiness there, too. *We gotta get outta here, we gotta go home, or somebody needs our help . . .* Some reason to leave the party and do something else . . .

But India said, "Angel, you seen Jasmine?"

"No, not for a while."

The other girl said, "I'll go look for her out back."

Angel said, "What's going on?"

"We gotta find Jasmine," India said, holding Angel's wrist, but scanning the faces of the partiers in the frat's front room.

"Did something happen?"

“No, we gotta find her, or Beck, or—”

That was when Abby came into the kitchen, looking to refill her solo cup.

“—or anybody.”

India dragged Angel to follow into the kitchen saying to Abby, “Jesus, there you are, where the hell were you?”

“I was in the yard,” she said, near inebriated.

“You jerk, come here, I been looking all over for you.”

“What?”

“You seen Jasmine?”

“She left.”

“Jasmine left?”

“Jasmine left with that fucking guy, what’s that guy from the basketball team? . . .”

“Shit.”

“What’s up?”

Angel drifted, her and India’s arms straightening, but India’s hand still held hers tight. She snapped her close. “Angel, stay here.” Then to Abby, “Have you seen Beck?”

“I think she went upstairs.”

“With a Chi guy?”

When Abby said yeah, India sighed, “Gross,” then: “Check it out,” and withdrew from her purse a pale paper envelope. She flipped up the

envelope's tongue and withdrew a blank card, opened the card and showed them three stubs of red paper like bookmarks with forked ends. They were printed in black gothic letters, raised from the texture of the paper that was stiff and embossed like linen.

Abby said, "What the hell is this?"

"That party Jasmine was talking about."

"What party?—oh yeah."

India smiled. "You want to go?"

Abby was unsure. "Where is it?"

India said, "The address's on the stubs. Look it up."

That was something Angel could do, and it would keep her hands busy. She said she'd do it, and India showed her the tickets. Hull House. She typed the address and got the location on a map. "Yeah," she said, "it's an estate. It's like, I don't know, twenty minutes out of town." Her stomach knotted. She turned up her nose, saying, "Sounds kind of far."

Abby laughed. "Yeah, we should go to a party at a mansion in the woods. Sounds like a really good idea. Mountain hillbillies. You two go, nice knowing you."

"Come on, I've got three tickets," India said. "It's supposed to be good."

"Good why?"

"Number one," India said, "it's not a fucking frat party."

India's tone got Abby thinking. She ran a loose strand of her burgundy hair behind an ear, tugged at the collar of her black dress. "What kind of party is it?"

“I don’t know, details are super sketch. Like, *older* people.”

Abby rolled her eyes. “No way, not going to an old person party.”

“No, like a *function*. Rich people. Music, bar, entertainment, the whole thing, but it’s expensive. Tickets are limited, like, these stubs here, Abby, look at me . . .” India waited till Abby looked her way. “. . . Are like five-hundred a pop.”

Now Abby’s eyebrows went up, considering it. She picked up one ticket, examined it with new reverence. Expensive paper, elaborate printing, and the party was \$500 per head to get in? Angel knew how Abby’s brain worked.

Abby said, “I guess I’m in.”

“Shit, well, all right, player,” India said and held out a slender hand for a gentle girl-style high-five.

India presented her hand to Angel for a high-five. “You in? . . .”

Everything in her brain said nope. *That’s okay, I’m just going to go back to the dorm, I have a bunch of Edith Wharton to read. Work, work, work, you know how it is, girls, plus, well, kinda pulled a hamstring running today. But you girls go on, have fun, I’m sure you will, text me later, let me know how it’s going, India, I’ll see you when you get in . . .*

But the two girls stared at her, measuring her value. Two beautiful girls. And what the hell, she was in college for the full experience, wasn’t she? Yeah, of course the education, but she didn’t want to miss all that the experience offered. . . . Plus, merit was fleeting. Angel offered little as a friend, but India was kind and considerate. If she retreated now, how much longer would India’s hand be held out in friendly offer? . . . She looked at

India's palm; soft, moisturized, the underside tips of her fingernails showing, manicured, the gold band of rings in the insets of her fingers . . .

Though it was the last thing she expected to do, Angel gave India the gentle high-five she sought.

Then wished she could take it back.

4

legend of hull house

THE THREE OF THEM TOOK AN UBER OUT OF THE VILLAGE OF Morrison, heading on the Number 9, or what the locals called the Margot Heavens Trail, into the woods and mountains almost twenty minutes before their driver slowed, checking her Toyota's nav screen.

“Righty, it’s up ahead,” she said. Their driver was a middle-aged woman, an empty-nester with gray hair, called Sammy. She’d talked to them about the college then told them about her hobbies, her funny calico cat, and her baking. As they passed out of the town and got in the woods, Sammy asked them where the address was in relation to the Hull House. They said it *was* the Hull House, and Sammy said that was why they must have been dressed up so nicely.

The Hull House, Sammy said, used to be public, and when she was a kid going to Morrison Primary, they’d have field trips out there to see the place preserved for history, the rooms decorated from the time period it was built, and even mannequins dressed up how the original owners might have.

“Grover G. Hull, that’s the guy built it, got all his money in mining out west in California, moved back to his home state and built this mansion for his wife, was right after the Civil War,” she’d said.

And now Sammy's Toyota was turning onto the road leading into the Hull House, the entrance guarded by two small houses lit by floodlights, groundskeeper's houses, Sammy said, passing through and following a gravel road under a colonnade of denuded November maples. They passed more outbuildings; a barn, a cottage, and even a white clapboard building that looked like it might have served as a church at one time.

All three girls lined up in the back seat, watched out the windows; soon the roadway was lined with lanterns, the gaps between them hung with ivory linen bunting and small twinkling lights. A thump of music could be heard, and now Abby was alert, leaning forward to peer through the windshield over Sammy's shoulder.

"Whoa, look at this place," Abby said, wowed, as the Uber pulled into the broad expanse of Hull House's dooryard, lined up with cars. Angel noted they were airport rentals, or expensive German sedans—there were even two limos.

Tension worked through her back and jaw. They weren't supposed to be here. This wasn't a party for college kids, it was obvious. They'd likely get rejected at the door, or perhaps even in trouble with the school.

She said, "It's okay we have those tickets?"

India said, "Yeah, what do you mean?"

"I don't want to get in trouble."

Abby chuckled, looked back at India like a joke was exchanged.

She got it: It was an Angel thing to say, Angel the wet blanket nerd. She'd shut up.

When the Toyota's path curved so it was broadside and the girls could disembark and head up the mansion's steps, they all got a good look at the

place. The house was huge, intricate and elaborate, absolutely everything she thought was Victorian: mansard roofs, octagonal turrets, fish scale shingles, a wraparound porch with woodwork webbing braces like gingerbread cutouts . . . it looked like a dollhouse, and there was a time when she was little and off school for a week with a flu, she and her mother worked on this enormous jigsaw puzzle on a card table they'd moved into the sunroom so they could sit by the fire. It was a fond memory, and the house reminded her of the picture on the puzzle: a painting of this huge Victorian scene in snowy winter, all these ladies in their long dresses walking a shoveled sidewalk out front of a grand old home.

India paid Sammy on her phone, gave a good tip, bent down and graciously thanked her, then closed the door. The woman's maternal energy had her waiting in the Toyota to make sure the girls made it to the front door of the party before leaving.

India walked up the porch's three steps first, and since Abby wobbled, Angel supported her, tentatively resting a hand in the center of the girl's back.

At the top of the stairs, standing out front of the house's door, a man waited for them. The guy was obviously security. But, unlike the frat house's security, this guy (who was also the size of a football player) wore a black suit, standing upright and professional, hands clasped below his waist. He nodded to them coming, gestured for them to approach in a pleasant but confident way. "Welcome to Hull House, ladies, you have no chaperones?"

India was all big city charm now, saying in a confident singsong, "It's just the girls tonight," while she faced him. In her hands she held the envelope with a red ticket stub protruding from the open flap. The security man regarded it, nodded to her, and she presented the envelope. Music pulsed from somewhere within the mansion, but she couldn't see inside because of

the porch light's reflection on the front entry doors—two enormous oaken slabs inset with stained glass.

Tickets checked, the man passed back the envelope to India. Everything was in order, because now the security guard opened the door for them and gestured to enter. “Have a wonderful evening, ladies.”

India thanked him, Abby giggled drunkenly, and Angel kept her head down, following the other two inside the mansion.

Now they were in the foyer.

The music was louder, and beyond the foyer they could see attendees passing from left to right. There were men in dark suits, a guy in a black military uniform or something, a woman in some sort of headdress and a cocktail gown, all dark colors and sparkling jewelry . . . Another person passed by, and it looked as though they wore a black cloak.

“Jesus,” Abby sighed, eyes wide, then giggled again.

The space they were in opened above to an enormous dangling globe chandelier, the second-floor balcony looked down on them, a staircase winding the right-hand wall to the black and white tile floor. There were red rugs, real live oil paintings on the wall, potted ferns, ornate furniture, and ahead of them, acting as a barrier before entering the mansion proper, a long ornate table stretched across the threshold. In front of the table were two men in suits, much like the one who'd allowed them to enter.

A woman sat casually on the table, legs crossed, high-heel shoes not touching the floor. Despite her casual demeanor, she had an officious quality, turning their way and studying them, light obliterating her gaze as her glasses reflected the chandelier's glow. She was a middle-aged woman with pulled back hair, a steady stoic expression that took them in. She registered all at once: three girls, young ones, un-chaperoned like the man

out front had noticed as well, but she could see they held three red tickets, and they were dressed all in black which seemed like it might be appropriate here. Slowly, she smiled. She waved for them to approach, and the security guards who'd been talking to her stepped back and assumed official poses.

Angel came up behind India as she passed the tickets to the woman who slipped off the table now, checked an open book on the table, examined the numbers on the tickets to see if they matched her records.

"It's wonderful to have you here this evening," she said, eyes on the binder. She stood then and faced them. "Your tickets allow you to the main room. Please stick to the main room, unless you have an escort, and if I could have your phones . . .?"

Abby snorted: "Our *phones*?" Incredulous.

On an upholstered chair next to the table sat a large wicker basket. The woman flipped open the basket's lid, and inside were canvas pouches. She withdrew three and lay them on the table. "No phones, ladies, you're aware of the rules."

India said, "Yeah, okay. Yondr."

Abby murmured, "This is a phone free zone," but she was getting into it now, not liking her incredulity in case it didn't make her sound hip to what this was all about.

"Phones go in the pouches, ladies, your phone will still receive messages, and if you must respond you can leave the premises by one of the designated exits, and there will be a device there that will unlock the pouch. But you must come back in through the front door, and pass by me."

India passed Angel a pouch for her phone. It wasn't canvas, it was tough like Kevlar. She slipped her phone inside the pouch, suddenly feeling very separated from the real world. When the clasp closed over, it locked.

The officious woman checked all their pouches to make sure that the clasps had locked. "Pass your pouch over our posted electronic devices as you leave, and that will unlock it. Leave the pouch. So no pictures, no texting, no communications within the walls of the mansion. You understand?" She smiled slyly while she instructed, then added: "You're voyeurs, but the mansion is eyes only."

"Absolutely," India said, slipped the canvas pouch that contained her phone into her pocket book. Angel put hers in her skirt pocket, making it bulge.

The security guard to their right, a menacing hulk with a dense black beard and shaved head, extended a hand to them. "May I take your coats?"

India and Abby surrendered theirs; Angel shrugged, mouth quirked, embarrassed. He passed India and Abby the matching tags for their coats, then disappeared into a side room where there were rows of metal racks hosting files of partygoers plastic-shrouded outerwear.

There were a million questions. What is this party? . . . All we have are tickets, but we don't know what's going on here—can you tell us? . . . Is it even okay that we're here? . . . We're not really supposed to be at this place, I don't think . . . Is it okay we're not of age? . . . Are we going to get in trouble? . . .

The woman said, "One more thing—your medallions," taking now from a pile three gold coins on black ribbon. They looked like Olympic medals for some nefarious activity. "You wear them in the mansion, and enjoy yourself . . ." She looked them up and down, and there was a measure of puzzlement on the woman's face. They had tickets, they weren't going to be rejected,

but Angel could read in the woman's stare she realized these girls *weren't* supposed to be here. Her stomach made a sound, and she was glad it was drowned out by the sound of the party beyond.

5

chevrons

PAST THE THRESHOLD THEY STOOD IN A HALLWAY THAT RAN TO THEIR left and right, heading deeper into the mansion's wings. But there were guards posted, one on their left, one on their right, standing in black suits. The woman had said they were allowed in the main room, so she imagined getting past the guards would require an escort. Whatever that might mean.

Straight ahead and down three steps was a cavernous main room, maybe once a ballroom or a family room. It was wide open, and the ceiling extended high above balconies that looked down from the second floor. Around the balconies, partygoers strolled, some arm in arm, some in groups, all of them in some style of costume. And looking across the main room, the ballroom, it was clear now this was a costume party, or perhaps the more accurate term: masquerade. People wore masks, headdresses, outfits in leather, elaborate ball gowns. Some men wore tuxedos. Other wore leather strap outfits like one of those old Matrix movies but with exposed skin. Angel's stomach dropped and her hands went to ice.

"We should go," she whispered.

But when she looked India and Abby's way the amusement on their pretty faces showed there was no way they would be leaving just yet.

“Guys, like seriously,” she said, voice so quiet no one heard her.

India hooked Abby’s arm tight to herself, lips peeled in a wide and beautiful smile that showed off her perfect teeth. She walked ahead, helping Abby down the stairs, and Angel had to trot to keep up.

Maybe this kind of party wasn’t unusual to a girl who grew up in Beverly Hills, but it was definitely another planet for Angel. This was a historical mansion in the middle of the woods, in the Green Mountains of Vermont, but it was what she’d feared the frat party might look like, then amplified more than double in scariness. No one was their age. Some were middle-aged, some in their late twenties, but there definitely wasn’t anyone from Morrison here.

Two good-looking older women in hunter green cloaks laughed as the person they were talking to, a heavily made-up woman who had to be six-two in heels, maybe a drag performer, pulled back the bodice of her elaborate costume with a Velcro tear and revealed to them her bare breasts. Angel looked away, but it registered they might not be real, the way the nipples were colored and the lack of jiggle or sway.

Abby doubled over as she walked, laughing so she couldn’t breathe, and India shushed her, laughing to herself as well, not at the spectacle of the party it seemed, but at Abby.

India said, “Abby, baby, let’s get you to the couch.”

The party moved around them like movies she’d seen about extravagant pre-Revolution France; there was even a string quartet in the corner, their instrument-playing mostly drowned out by the solid beat coming from beyond the main room, looking like there might be a dance floor with electronic music playing outside in a garden. Bodies jumped up and down outside the windows, arms raised, lights flashing in rainbow colors. There

was a serving bar in the corner, done up like a carnival carousel without the mannequin horses; there were couches and chaises everywhere, arranged in circles and semi-circles and most of them were fully occupied. But India led them to a couch now with no one else on it, getting Abby to sit down. Angel got up close to India, saying, “Have you ever seen anything like this before?”

“Like this?” She laughed, blew a brief raspberry. “No way, not even close—can you *believe* this?”

“No,” she said, scanning the room, disbelieving.

Morrison was in the middle of nowhere. What were all these people doing here, all together, all with the same proclivity? . . . This wasn’t like Vermont at all.

And she’d been worried about the frat party.

India was saying, “Abs, baby, what do you want to do—should we go outside to the music?”

“Yeah, sure,” Abby said, rubbing her hands on her thighs and taking it all in, head moving from left to right.

Across the room, a man in a black cloak watched them, face without expression, hands together at his front like the security guards, but he didn’t have that blunt force trauma look to him. There was sharp watchful knowledge in his black eyes. Angel was sure now this would be the man who asked them to leave.

Abby asked India, “Do you think we could get a drink from the bar? I don’t have I.D. . . .” When Abby’d looked to India, her eyes wandered to Angel, then over Angel’s shoulder. Her expression stiffened, and she smirked. Angel looked over her shoulder to see what had provoked Abby’s smirk.

A man had his eyes on Abby. A *man*, not a college guy. Had to be in his thirties, good-looking, tanned bronze, gleaming black hair, but a seamed face. He wore a suit, not a costume; black wool, white shirt, black tie. His watch gleamed at them.

“Well, hello,” Abby muttered slyly.

The sight of one of her compatriots, her own age, remarking that way about a grown man got Angel’s stomach dropping. Would Abby really consider someone like that? When she glanced over her shoulder, she saw the man approaching now. *Oh God . . .*

In front of their couch was a low wooden table shining with gloss, a bouquet of real flowers in the center with pastel blossoms almost as big as cut cabbages. The man came around the far side of the table, all the girls tracking him. He sat next to Abby, who looked at him, saying, “Hi-i,” and doing it in a breathy sing-song.

He touched her hair, lounging comfortably in the corner of their couch and eyeing this nineteen-year-old seductively. India patted Angel’s knee, like she wanted her attention, like she was afraid Angel was missing this show.

The man said to Abby: “You’re a voyeur?” His voice was deep, the tone of his remark tilted slightly upward at the end so it served as a question.

“I sure am,” Abby said, impish, cocking her head. The man smiled at her.

“What’s your name?”

“What’s yours?”

“Maybe we don’t need names,” the man said.

“I’ve got by without one before,” Abby said, and India’s back shook with laughter, watching her friend work with this older man.

The man chuckled softly. Angel looked down at the medallion resting between her breasts. It was unremarkable, just a gold coin, a large one, not possibly real gold, though it was heavy. Across the center was a raised chevron. A V. V for voyeur. Is that what the man meant saying to Abby she was a voyeur? . . .

“You’re very beautiful,” the man said.

“I know.”

He smiled, touched her shoulder. “I’d love for you to come back to my chamber, see what I’m doing there.”

India interjected over Abby’s shoulder. “Some sort of project?”

The man frowned at her, the smirk still there. “A project. Yes.”

This was suddenly more than Angel could bear. It was like they were in a den of serial killers and this man was trying to lure their friend to his back room to torture her and everyone here at this party would be okay with that. “We should go,” she whispered near India’s ear.

Without turning around India held up a finger indicating to wait. But there was too much they didn’t know; they wore medallions that signified something they weren’t aware of—

The man in black she’d seen watching them from across the room was there now with them and she hadn’t even seen him coming. He kneeled next to the handsome man Abby’d been talking to, all confident smiles and addressing the man. “Good evening, Mr. Fairbanks, I hope you’re enjoying your stay.”

The man smiled, nodded once almost imperceptibly, polite but not enjoying the interruption.

“I’m afraid you’ll have to move on from these young voyeurs so I may deal with them.”

Oh no. This was where they got taken to a room in the back and made to wait while the police he’d called showed up to return them to to the dorm, the dean waiting for them.

The man named Mr. Fairbanks didn’t like being refused, but he regarded Abby, then back to the man with the cloak and the black eyes, and nodded once again. He said to Abby, “I’ll be around later, if you see me, come to me.”

“Maybe,” Abby said, making him sneer. He rose and left.

Angel said, “Did we do something wrong?”

The man said to Abby, “How are you, young lady?”

“I’m doing fine.” She had a smile that went off to one side of her face. A defiant sort of expression, like a young woman who might be used to fighting back or at least complaining to the manager.

“You’ve had some drinks tonight, haven’t you?” He tapped her knee with an index finger, big wide smile, encouraging her to be honest.

“No, I—”

He stopped her. “It doesn’t matter. Maybe you’re of age, maybe not, but you won’t be served here. And I will not allow you to go to a room with a man. For *your* sake. Not when you’ve been drinking. Not even to watch.”

“I’m of age,” she lied.

While she came at the man with a measure of indignation, he was still all smiles and charm and confidence.

“I’m sure you are, love,” he said, “just the same, I’m the master of this room, and I command you to the dance floor where you may cut the rug all night long or whatever Morrison girls are saying these days. May I get you a cup of coffee, a soft drink perhaps?”

Whatever magic worked in the guy’s black eyes, it got Abby laughing and she said, “I’ll just dance, thank you very much.”

India thanked the man, and he winked at her. The guy had a weird dominant paternal sort of energy, like he really looked out for Abby, not just lip service. He’d seen that man called Mr. Fairbanks would prey on her and he intervened for her safety. A warmer feeling came over her, and while the man left them, she called out a thank you. He waved over his shoulder like he was saying think nothing of it, and he returned to the far wall where it seemed he monitored the party.

“From weird to weirder,” India sighed, watching the man, Abby slumping to lean against her shoulder.

Abby said, “Take me to the dance floor, please.”

India laughed and patted Abby’s cheek like she was a child, then took her hand. She offered the other one to Angel saying, “You coming?”

Angel put out her hand, but paused, looking over her shoulder and the partygoers, seeing the people dancing outside in the flashing lights. That wasn’t her out there. She didn’t want to go to the dance floor.

“Maybe I’ll stay here,” she said.

India’s face showed she didn’t like that idea. “You sure about that?”

“I think I’ll people watch,” she said, then nodded her chin across the room to the man with the black magic eyes. “He’s looking out.”

Abby said, “I don’t think Angel’s a dancer.” The tone was hard to decipher as friendly or disparaging.

“I’m not,” she said, staying seated in the corner of the couch.

“Suit yourself,” India said, “are you going to run off with Abby’s boyfriend Mr. Fairbanks?” Abby cackled.

“I’m happy here, I think,” she said.

Abby said, “Go check out his project. His big, long, *hard* project.”

India laughed and nudged Abby.

“You better be here when we come back,” India said.

Angel knew she was a burden to them now, not wanting to go to the dance floor when the three of them should be sticking together in a strange place like this. “Please don’t worry about me,” she said, almost regretting the words as soon as she’d said them. If they took them to heart and Mr. Fairbanks took her down one of the mansion’s wings she could be dismembered while Abby and India were heading back to Morrison.

“Poke around, Angel,” Abby said, “you might find what you’re looking for—guy like Mr. Fairbanks’s a legit Sugar Daddy, I can feel it. My sister goes to Penn, says she knows a girl there with a sugar daddy bought her like a whole wardrobe, a car even. I mean, who knows what she had to suck to get it, but, hey, right? . . .”

Angel gave a nervous laugh, trying to be polite but also parsing Abby’s suggestion for insult. Was it because Angel’s wardrobe was so obviously needing to be replaced? Was it because she thought Angel couldn’t get a real boyfriend? Did she so badly look like she needed money she’d benefit from a rich, old, sugar daddy?

Even India made an uncomfortable face hearing Abby's suggestion. She said, "Angel, baby, I want you to be careful. Abs and I are just outside. Don't . . . Don't *fall* for anything. You know what I'm saying?"

"I'll be all right here," she said and smiled.

India cocked her head, sighed, hugged her arm around Abby tighter. "Let's cut a rug like good Morrison girls."

Abby laughed, said, "Lead the way, lead the way . . ."

6

the watcher

FIELD NOTES FROM HER STUDY: THERE WERE OUTSIDERS LIKE HER, ones who didn't seem to participate, but unlike her at least seemed to know what the function was all about. . . . The mood was generally high. . . . There were others, separate from the watchers, or voyeurs, ones who did not wear gold medallions, who acted as though they portrayed characters from a show or literature. . . . At times she felt there was an atmosphere similar to one of the comic-cons that Brian had made her go to. People took roles, but Angel was unsure whether they imitated something from a culture she was unfamiliar with, or if there was some storytelling going on. Like this may be an elaborate murder mystery party, or dinner theater. . . . Whether one wore a costume did not dictate their behavior. . . . The ones without gold medallions fell into two groups: mean or meek. The meeker ones always gave heed to the meaner ones, like bullies in the school halls. Occasionally a mean one, usually all in black, would emerge from one of the mansion's wings and find a meek one sitting on a couch or in a group politely talking and they would summon the meek one to join them. Those interactions were watched by the man with the black eyes. . . . Angel watched the watcher. . . . So if the meek were not voyeurs, what was it for which they were summoned to the mansion's wings? It was curious, but wildly entertaining.

But just as she remarked to herself the good fortune in staying seated alone on the couch, that changed.

Her fascinating surveillance of the party was waning, and she was looking forward to India and Abby returning, or maybe even thinking of seeking them out, feeling relaxed now, or at least more at ease with the nature of the party. She could stand at the edge of the dance floor and watch the others have a good time . . . A woman arrived at the party, standing out due to the bright copper of her huge mane of hair. She'd passed the desk, must have got her phone locked up by the woman out front, and now she stood at the ballroom's threshold taking in the party's spectacle. She dressed all in black, but not costumed. The clothes had that expensive look; they clung to her generous frame. The woman wasn't young, but wasn't old. Maybe thirty. The neck of her dress plunged to her sternum, the white creamy skin of her chest beaming in the party's light. The woman had a generous figure; vivacious, with big hips and thighs, swelling bosom, but a narrow waist, neck, and knees. Angel studied her. The woman caught herself being studied and simultaneously saw the couch where her peeper sat was empty. She headed toward Angel. Angel shifted, and her heart rate picked up.

The woman stepped down into the ballroom, curly red hair bouncing, weaving through passing partygoers dressed in black leather, and Angel avoided eye contact now. The woman came around the table and the bouquet of comically large flowers then sat down on the other end of the couch and crossed one leg over the other. Angel side-glanced, saw the woman's dress skirt split, her bare white knee and thigh exposed. The woman's legs were freckled. Angel watched the woman in her periphery. The woman fidgeted; adjusted her dress where it was tight around her middle. She looked around like a woman seeking a waiter. She was nervous. No, not nervous, anxious.

When Angel chanced a more direct glance, the woman caught her, gave a nervous—no, anxious—smile. “Hey,” she said.

Angel said hi in return, then her eyes went to the woman’s shoes. A line of red along the side, red soles like those expensive shoes India wore.

“I got here kind of late,” the woman said, her voice strained and breathy. Nerves. Anxiety. Still she looked around.

The man with the black eyes standing at the edge of the party watched from the redhead to the bar and back. A waiter was coming with a drink on a tray held at his shoulder. But no drink had been ordered; the woman had only arrived. No drinks were offered to Angel and her friends. . . . Was that because they were so obviously underage? Probably.

Angel said, “Do you want to know what you missed?” trying to be light and funny to make the woman feel more at ease, like they could be friends in their shared overwhelm.

“No,” the woman laughed and Angel wasn’t insulted. She was joking.

The waiter arrived and offered the redheaded woman a drink which she thanked him for then took a sip. It was sparkling and clear with a big disk of lemon wedged on the rim. Possibly alcoholic, but not confirmed. The waiter left without saying a thing.

The woman leaned forward to set the drink on the table saying, “I almost didn’t come at all. Almost chickened right out . . .”

Now she rubbed her hands on her thighs. Anxious. Expectant. Fingers clawed, nails scratching. She wore no wedding ring, but her other jewelry looked impressive. She scanned the room while Angel folded her arms to protect herself from the woman’s radiating anxiety.

“I’m Kelly,” the woman said without looking Angel’s way.

“I’m Angel.”

“That’s a great name,” the woman said, then gave a short tight laugh. She looked Angel’s way. “You’re a voyeur?”

“Unintentional, I guess. But, yes.”

Kelly chewed her lip, eyes unable to stay still, scanning the room. Her legs were jumping. She leaned to take her glass, sipped, missed her mouth and spilled a little on her chin. On Angel’s side of the table there was an errant cocktail napkin, clean and unused, and she passed it to Kelly who wiped her chin.

“Thanks,” she said, “I’m not usually so—”

Angel regarded Kelly when she stopped speaking. Kelly’s eyes had stopped moving, locked somewhere across the room. She spoke to herself in a whisper: “Oh shoot, oh no, oh Kelly, Kelly, Kelly, it’s too late now . . .”

Angel followed Kelly’s line of sight and saw of what she must be fearful. A man stood on the threshold of the ballroom having come from one of the wings. He was tall. Imposing. Dressed all in black, he wore a frightful mask that gleamed in gold. It looked like the face of a dragon, eyes wide and baleful, short sharp horns poking above lowered brow, fangs bared. Not a dragon, no, Japanese . . . One of those demons—were they called Oni . . .?

Louder now, fearful but standing her ground (or sitting), Kelly said, “Here we go, Angel, this is real . . .”

The man’s mask faced them, unwavering, those black mask eye holes watching Kelly. He stepped down to the ballroom with quick steps, moving slow but light despite his size. The closer the man got the larger Angel realized he was. Maybe six and a half feet tall, long legs and arms, broad

shoulders. Under his flowing black cloak he wore a suit, also all in black. Black shirt, black tie; he wore gauntlets in black leather.

Around the table and its flowers the masked man came to stand by Kelly who looked up not saying a thing now. The man's mask tilted downward, the eyes behind the mask staring into Kelly's eyes. He held her face in his black leather glove. Angel watched Kelly's throat jump as she gulped a swallow.

The approach of the demon-man wasn't dissimilar to what she'd earlier witnessed. Someone would come from the wings, find a meek partner and take them away. But something more dynamic occurred here. Kelly showed more fear than the others, and the man with the Oni mask showed more menace.

The man's gloved fingers stroked Kelly's pretty face, and Angel was glad to see a blush rise on the woman's cheeks because whatever was happening next to her on the couch, Angel's own cheeks were burning. The man's thumb parted the woman's plump lips, pushed into her mouth. Kelly was reluctant, but she closed her mouth on his thumb and began to suck. The act was shocking and lewd and Angel looked away.

Other partygoers were watching too, like they also sensed this man and this redheaded woman were different.

Kelly grunted a pained sound, and Angel turned to see her being brought to her feet by the man who held her by a fistful of her gorgeous red hair.

"Hey," Angel said, but her voice was timid and quiet and unheard, and even though she'd tried to rise to defend Kelly, she was still seated, heart hammering now.

Kelly held the man's wrist to alleviate the pain of his hair-pulling. She was on her feet, pigeon toed, beautiful face contorted. "Angel," she grunted,

“would you come with me?”

“Me?”

“Come watch for me, please,” Kelly said, eyes closed, teeth clenched, her voice tight and pleading.

“But . . .”

It was too late to negotiate because the man led her away by a handful of hair in his leather grip. He walked Kelly who toddled on tip toes ahead of him.

Angel stood but didn’t follow. She turned back to the dance floor beyond the windows, lights still flashing, people still jumping around out there, no sign of India or Abby. She wrung her hands together. A man nearby scowled directly her way. Admonishment. Kelly’d asked her to come, and she wasn’t following. Breaking protocol. Against party rules. . . . But what if it was more? What if Kelly really needed help? What if Angel needed to serve as Kelly’s Watcher like the man with the black eyes had protected Abby from Mr. Fairbanks?

“Ah, shoot, shoot, *shoot*,” she hissed, bouncing in place. Then she was off, trotting in Kelly and the tall man’s wake, trying to catch up before they disappeared in the mansion’s wings . . .

7

oni

WHILE SHE FOLLOWED, LOAFERS TAPPING UP THE STEP, HER HAND went on instinct to the phone in her skirt pocket, but at the padded and bulky feel she remembered that would be impossible. The phone was locked in a Kevlar pouch. Word should be given to India and Abby, but how would she do that?

The man with the mask led redhead Kelly past the security guard at the arched doorway that opened into one of the wings. Angel sped up, but went straight to the guard standing with no expression in his black suit, hands clasped at his front.

“Um, hi,” she said, out of breath, “I’m supposed to follow them,” she gestured to Kelly and the man, one hand presenting the medallion on its ribbon, “but my friends are outside dancing—they won’t know where I am . . .”

The man watched her, blank, said nothing.

“So I guess . . . can I get past?”

The security guard still said nothing, but she could see a passing amusement on his face.

“I can come back out if I want?”

He nodded, gestured for her to enter the hallway.

One more look back hoping to see India’s or Abby’s face in the ballroom crowd, then she was off to follow Kelly hoping India wouldn’t be mad at her coming out to find the couch empty . . .

THE WING’S hallway was wide, perhaps fifteen feet or more across. The ceiling vaulted high above, and there were doors down the hallway as far she could see, interspaced and opposing each other almost every twenty feet. Around each doorway, partygoers were gathered. No sense of organization, just a haphazard semicircle of onlookers, spectators obviously who were watching something happening within each of the rooms.

As she hustled along the wide carpet runner that traveled the length of the hall, she tried peeping in the rooms each time she passed a huddle of people. There was never a chance to see what was occurring within, but she could hear. One room she heard moans. Another room she heard a man protesting, a slapping sound followed. The crowd bristled as she passed. Had the man been struck? Tightness worked inside her, but she gained on Kelly and the man with the demon mask. Once she was right behind them, passing more doorways, more potted plants, more huddles of people, she watched the man’s polished leather shoes clopping on the red wool rug.

The man turned sharply at a T intersection, going left, pushing Kelly ahead of him still holding her by the hair. Kelly took quick shuffling steps while the man strode. Her calf muscles flexed, walking on her toes so the hair pulling wouldn’t hurt as much. Occasionally she would grunt, but the man didn’t slow.

The hallway they'd turned into was quiet. There were doorways down this hall, but only one door was open and by it stood an older gentleman in a tuxedo. Not a black tie, but a white tie and white vest. As they drew nearer, he gestured a white gloved hand for them to enter the room's double doors. Angel looked to the man for confirmation that she was accepted as well; he gave her no response, but didn't stop her either. She slipped in behind Kelly and her tormentor.

The room was large and quiet. A tall room, a high coffer ceiling, the spaces between the wood beams painted with Victorian images; rose bushes and fruit and bugling angels with red wings. . . . At the back of the room sat a large full-size grand piano in shining black, the lid open, the keyboard and seat unattended. Past that were windows that must look outside to the eastern part of the estate's grounds. But the towering curtains were closed, showing only their dull bronze color embroidered with paisley shapes.

People were gathered there waiting for their arrival.

Propped in the center of the room was what looked like a table cocked upright at a 90° angle. Eight feet tall, six feet wide, polished wood set on a metal stand that braced it from behind. Next to the upright table sat a push cart lined with instruments. This spectacle was arranged on the center of a large Persian rug. Around the perimeter of the rug, sitting on chairs, some standing, were an arrangement of a dozen people, mostly men, though there were three women in ball gowns and eye masks. The men wore various costuming, and the crowd looked international. A wealthy man in white robes who looked like he might own oil fields in the Middle East; an octogenarian with a broad face and black sunglasses blotting his eyes who wore a gold trimmed kufi on his graying head, looking like an African dictator in white robes and wooden jewelry, seated on a chair with his legs apart; behind him a much younger woman in bright satiny robes and a teal head wrap; a trio of Asian businessmen in black suits and white shirts

buttoned to the collars, no ties, faces expressionless; three gangster-like men in their fifties, large and foreboding, arms hanging apish in their tight suits, balding, small black eyes . . . Close to the table, standing in an arrangement like a boys choir, were half a dozen young men nearer her own age. Close to college-age, seniors maybe, or older than that but not over twenty-five. They were clean-shaven, light brown or blonde hair brushed back from their faces, Aryan, with sharp chins and pronounced cheekbones. Handsome, though. handsome in the way that intimidated her.

Like a cast of suspects in a Sherlock Holmes mystery.

All attendees watched Kelly being marched into the room by her hair, tapping along in her expensive red sole tiptoes. The man with the mask shoved her, releasing her hair, and Kelly stumbled forward, coming to rest in the center of the rug standing next to the tilted table. She looked worried, hands clasped in front of her with fingers woven together. Her eyes traveled all those watching her and none of them showed a friendly face. But she didn't ask or babble about what would happen to her, didn't question why she was brought here, just stood there waiting . . .

The man with the demon mask said nothing, had so far been voiceless, and now he walked around her, looking her up and down, and Kelly dipped her chin in a timid pose. The man circumambulated, hands behind his back, then came around to stand before her. Fully a head taller, Kelly's eyes lingered somewhere in the center of his chest.

He touched a knuckle under her chin and tilted her face to look up. When she did, he pushed her backward, guiding her to step an arm's breadth away. Her lips trembled. The man touched her neck, his huge hand spreading down her collar between her breasts. He tucked a finger in the center V of her dress's blouse, where it plunged to her sternum. He ran the finger up sharply, following the dress's bodice, swooped to her shoulder then tugged

it down her arm. Her flesh shook, her black bra exposed, creamy bosom swell cupped in its lacy embrace. He touched the finger along the bra's hem, peeled downward until Kelly's nipple appeared. It was cherry pink; the bud hardened like the cherry's pit.

He did the same with the left side of her dress's bodice, but this time tugged forward sharply, making Kelly stumble a half step toward him, putting her hand on his stomach for balance. He allowed it, then pushed her to stand back, exposed in her torn away dress that hung over her hips at the dress's belt-line. She was bare from the waist up, wearing only her bra, one of her breasts exposed now, spilling out over the constraint of the black lace.

Angel looked at the gathered people, gauging their response. Was the woman an actress? Was this the audience? Who was the audience? Perhaps Angel was . . .

The man now wound a black leather finger in the air like helicopter blades, indicating for Kelly to turn around. She shuffled in place, turning till her backside faced them all and she stared at the blank glossy table. The man tossed her hanging tangle of beautiful copper hair over her shoulder, put spread fingers in the center of Kelly's naked back, urging her forward, and as she did, he grabbed the bra strap and ripped it apart. Kelly yelped, and Angel hissed knowing the pain that must cause, all those sharp fabric edges cutting into your skin . . .

Kelly's arms raised, Angel knowing Kelly was folding them across her bare breasts. The bra fell to her feet.

From the table now, the man with the mask picked up what looked like a horse riding crop. He patted the shaft's end with its looped leather tongue against his gauntlet's palm. It snapped threateningly. He studied Kelly now, dipped the end of the crop downward, touching the hem of Kelly's dress behind her knees. He lifted it upward, raised it to reveal to everyone the

backs of her thighs. Alarm rippled through Angel, making her arms shake. Her fingers went to pins and needles. Her lips grew cold.

With the riding crop, the man made Kelly's skirt dance higher until the triangle of her underwear was revealed where it curved over her ample and shapely bottom. Now members of the crowd shifted. Angel saw one of the women spread her fingers over her collar, and her cheeks had gone red.

She stepped closer, now standing on the carpet herself, very close, including herself in the gathered audience.

The man patted one of Kelly's ass cheeks with his gauntlet hand, and Kelly moaned. As she moaned, she tilted forward and put out a hand to brace herself on the facing table. The man came closer behind her, pressing his chest to her back, guiding her forward until her front touched the table. Her bare breasts were cuddled with one arm, the man taking one of her wrists and raising it overhead, his black cape swishing. At the top of the table, chains and loops of metal dangled; now Angel realized they were manacles. The man cinched one around Kelly's wrist, then put an arm around her to wrestle her other wrist, forcing it above her head and manacling it beside the other.

Now Kelly faced the table, pressed against it, both her hands extended above her head standing on tiptoes, her bare breasts squashed against the polished wood so that they ballooned around her rib cage. She breathed heavily, her ribs pressing out against the skin, her shoulder blades twitching as she tried to be comfortable bound the way she was. The man tucked his riding crop under an arm, went to the table and returned with small garden shears.

Seeing the blade edges gleam in the chandelier light above the table got Angel's knees shaking. The man wedged the nose of the shears down the waistband of the dress where it still cinched Kelly's waist. He scissored, the

shears eating their way down to Kelly's knees, until the dress was cut free, the fabric hanging in unseemly folds pinned against the table.

The man pulled the fabric free, and now Kelly was naked, pressed to the table wearing only panties. She had such a beautiful figure. It got Angel chewing the inside of her cheek seeing something so precious as this woman she met in the ballroom treated harshly, subjugated . . .

8

conservatory

WITH TWO SNIPS AT EACH HIP, THE MAN CUT FREE KELLY'S PANTIES. HE tossed the shears back onto the table where they rattled a hollow sound. Kelly's ass was bared to them all, her shorn panties stuck between her thighs. The man flossed them through, purposely tugging them upward so they threaded over the woman's sex and between her ass cheeks; one of the women in the room groaned, and Angel chewed her cheek too hard. Kelly shifted uncomfortably, hips going side to side, trying to get her legs apart so the panties could come free.

When she was stripped naked except for the heels, the man touched down her back, Kelly's beautiful mane of ginger hair tucked down her front side over one shoulder, baring her back. He stepped rearward, quickly snapped the crop tip against her ass cheek making Kelly shoot a sharp shriek, jumping in place. Her flesh shuddered, and slowly on the pale white globe of one ass cheek a red coin blossomed.

The man ran the crop tip around that rosy spot, teasing Kelly, putting it between her cheeks, slipping down to touch where she was a woman. When he withdrew the crop tip, he turned to show the gathered crowd the glistening leather; indicating this redheaded woman he'd dragged in here for their entertainment was wet.

The sexual cruelty squished and squirmed in Angel's stomach. This was far more than she could ever have anticipated. This wasn't dinner theater, some murder mystery production, this was bizarre and serious, and deeply frightening. The urge to flee sizzled through her but she fought it. Curiosity kept her, for sure, but also some measure of support for Kelly. Their interaction in the ballroom had been brief, but the way Kelly'd been dragged in here, and had asked for Angel's witness, had bonded them. She couldn't leave.

Her mind went into panic mode and she imagined possible escapes. How bold could she be? Could she interrupt, take away the man's riding crop, stare them all down as she helped Kelly get dressed so they could leave together? Would *she* end up on the table? Could she call for help? No one would come—by the looks of things, similar sadistic rituals were happening in the rooms she'd passed. She could run and find her friends, act casual, get outside, free her phone then call the police for help . . .

The man leaned against the table by Kelly's side, his gold demon face studying her, Kelly's face turned to the side and looking back at him. He caressed the back of her head, stroked her hair, ran his middle finger down her spine then spanked her bottom. He heaved off the table, pushed his foot down on a lever that ran below the table's edge. The table tilted forward like it was on hydraulics, Kelly laying across it now, the whole thing looking like some sort of magic trick, Kelly this evil magician's assistant. *And here, ladies and gentlemen, is where I saw this beautiful woman in half* . . .

The table not quite flat, but close, Kelly spread on it, he heeled the lever again to lock the table, moved to the bottom where Kelly's feet dangled off the edge. Kelly didn't fight, didn't kick, just allowed the man to remove her shoes. He dropped one to the floor, took the other and studied it, ran the heel point along the soles of her naked feet, getting her squirming on the

tabletop. She complained, and when she did, he spanked her dead center on the cheek he hadn't struck, her shoe's heel-point tapping the curve of her rump, getting her bouncing on the table.

Shoe tossed aside, he spread Kelly's legs, putting each ankle toward the corners of the table. Dangling below were more shackles hanging by chain, he dragged them up and locked her ankles in place, Kelly now pinned to the table hands above her head, legs spread.

The man looked at the gathered crowd, gesturing toward the woman he displayed on the table like she was his presentation. Like Mr. Fairbanks, this was the project the demon man was working on. What would Abby have thought, entering one of these back rooms with Mr. Fairbanks to see a display like this? Would she complain to the manager? . . .

The room was way too hot, the air thick and moist, and she struggled to take deep breaths as she watched what this man would do to her. Why wasn't Kelly protesting? She allowed the man to treat her this way . . .

He moved to the side of the table, began to knead Kelly's bottom, digging his thumbs into her soft curved flesh. He peeled apart Kelly's ass cheeks to show everyone that hidden part of her. There was a brief glimpse of Kelly's bright pink anus before Angel whipped her head away, feeling her cheeks, neck, collar, and ear tips blazing. Wooziness took hold of her, and she worried now she would stagger aside and collapse on the dictator's lap. She leaned forward and put her hands on her knees, forcing herself not to hyperventilate. If she fainted, who would watch out for Kelly?

Her lightheadedness attracted attention. Someone approached behind her, putting a hand on her back. She stepped forward, shaking off whoever it was, turning to see the older gentleman who'd ushered them in. His face was worried, he leaned close and whispered, "Would you like to sit or have a glass of water?"

She shook her head no, stood upright again, only now to see worse things happening to Kelly. She'd raised her ass in the air, her profile humped in the middle like an inchworm, and the man's black leather thumbs were opening her sex for everyone, showing Kelly's salmon pink insides to these well-dressed spectators.

Angel gasped, clutched the medallion hanging between her breasts, pulling downward and feeling the black ribbon strap cutting into the back of her neck. All she wanted to do was get out. Get the hell out. This was not for her. Kelly was on her own. This was all too crazy; she wanted to be home, not the dorm, not Vermont, but hiding under her rose pink quilt her mother'd made when she graduated from elementary to high school. Her big girl quilt, double padded, made with love . . . She sniffed, the noise wet and mucus loud. She wiped at her eyes that had begun to tear then looked aside hoping the butler man wasn't hanging around, relieved to see he'd left her alone.

Kelly mewled catlike, shimmying her hips, ashamed she was being presented to everyone, that most secret and intimate part of her being displayed—but not once did she tell the man with the golden demon mask to stop.

The urge came again, for her to brace hands on her knees and double over, a pose she sometimes assumed after a hard sprint, trying to get her heart level with her brain so she wouldn't pass out. If she were wearing her Fitbit, she wondered what her heart rate would be . . .

No one else seemed as perturbed as her, just watching this woman being humiliated and exposed on the table.

The man withdrew the crop from under his arm again, and as Kelly lowered her hips out of that uncomfortable inchworm position he snapped it against

her bottom, getting her to yelp. She raised back up, sticking her ass in the air, her naked interior exposed to everyone . . .

9

of flesh & peaches

WITH KELLY'S RUMP PUSHED UP IN THE AIR, THE MAN STOOD FOR A moment with his hands down, riding crop held between them, twisting his grip, leather squeaking. Angel and all the other spectators watched, shifting, making uncomfortable sounds wondering what would happen next.

At the push cart's countertop edge sat a small crock-pot bowl with a curled lip. The man held the riding crop butt-first above the crock-pot then lowered the crop's end into the bowl. He twirled then raised it. The bulbous leather butt glistened with a coating of clear gel.

More shifting, someone cleared their throat. An older man sitting beside the dictator crossed his legs over the other way, his chair squeaking.

The man with the mask returned his attention to Kelly, whose thighs flexed, her butt moving side to side and forward and back—Angel unsure if it was fear or anticipation. She moved her hand to her chest, then touched her own throat. Her forehead was hot, her fingers cold. She knew her cheeks would be red right now.

The man pushed the butt end of the crop in the space between Kelly's anus and vagina. Angel looked away, then shut her eyes tight. There was a slick crackling sound. Someone near her made a gasp. It was one of the women.

Angel squinted and looked back to the table. The man had inserted part of the crop's butt end into Kelly's vagina. He no longer held it, the handle inserted deep enough that it levitated from out between her butt cheeks. He tapped the stiff shaft with an index finger and got Kelly squirming on the table, trying to move the shaft away so he couldn't tap it. He tapped it more. Kelly flattened her stomach against the table.

Now the man touched his foot to the step-lever underneath the table, pushed on it to adjust the angle. The chains clinked as more of Kelly's weight was supported by the manacles that held her hands. The table was angled more upright, Kelly hanging, her legs still prevented from closing by the shackles around her ankles. He produced paddle, a shining flat of cherry wood with a short handle enough space for one hand.

The man tightened his grip on the handle, leather squeaking again. He tapped the blade edge of the paddle against the crop's shaft, like he reminded Kelly to keep her stomach flat. Kelly complied, pushing her pubic bones against the table, the riding crop laying almost flat, straight down between her legs now. With the crop out of the way, the man drew back his hand in a quick motion and brought the paddle in a bright slap against Kelly's bare, defenseless ass. Kelly howled.

The sharp cry of a woman in pain broke Angel's heart, and her brow furrowed. The hand at her throat clutched to a fist, and her eyes began to tear.

Again and again, the man slapped Kelly's ass with the wooden paddle. Each time, Kelly cried out in pain, struggled on the table, fought against the chains. It went on for minutes. Slap. Pause. Slap. Pause. . . . Those pale hands of Kelly's grabbed hold of the chains above her manacles and squeezed. She made crying sounds. She whimpered for him to stop. The

man didn't stop. Slap. Pause. Slap. Pause. Slap. . . . The crowd was breathless, watching with great intent.

One of the handsome college men in the tuxedos, standing close to the table and watching, shifted from foot to foot. He adjusted his pant leg, and the way the light shone on his fabric as he tugged showed he had an erection. Angel scowled, looked away. She was disgusted. Disgusted, but frozen in place.

Nothing preventing her from leaving. Some strange dedication to protecting this woman. Deep in her stomach something burned and throbbed. Like a glowing coal in a fire's morning bed of ash. Hot to touch, the slightest wind kicking up bright yellow color, bringing fire . . .

The young handsome man with the erection shifted again, actually holding it now over top of his pants, squeezing. All the boys shifted. She watched them. They were getting ready for something, adjusting their jackets. One of them tugged something from underneath his cummerbund, as if verifying it was still there. She saw the corner of a translucent plastic pouch. The young man tucked it back under the cummerbund.

The man's paddling increased in pace. The strikes came more rapid. Slap. Slap. Slap. Slap. No pauses. Kelly's ass had been bright white when it was bared. Now it was blushed red. All down her thighs, the entire globes of her cheeks a bright pink. Kelly shifted and fought against the strikes now. She cried out, "Stop, ow, oh okay, please, stop, stop . . ." But he didn't. The man kept paddling her.

Angel took a step forward, looking aside left and right to see if anybody else would interject. They all sat stone-faced. But she could see them aroused; their pupils widened, dilated, their eyes shimmering wet. Enlivened by what they watched. What was wrong with all of them that

they would stay here to witness this woman being hurt and humiliated this way?

She took one more step but stopped. No one else did a thing. *Shouldn't* she do something? Kelly cried out again and again, howling in pain, begging and begging him to stop. . . . Angel clutched both hands to her face, clawed at the skin under her eyes, going out of her mind. Caught in this horrible moment of knowing what was the right thing to do, but fear of breaking some unknown social protocol freezing her in place. Every sense she had told her to help Kelly. Stop this man from hurting her. But she did nothing . . .

The man stopped on his own.

Paddle returned to the push cart's top, he adjusted his cloak, returned to Kelly who made soft crying sounds into her own shoulder. He stooped, undid first the shackle on her right ankle than the left. Now she hung from just her wrists, her grip still squeezing the chains, her toes trying to touch the floor. The man went around behind the table; there was a metallic click, and Kelly slumped down the table to her feet, manacles still around her wrists, chains dragging over the edge of the tabletop to fall at her sides. But before she moved to collapse, the man embraced her, his movement quick and graceful. He set Kelly onto her knees so she faced the crowd. Her beautiful face was contorted, and she tried to hide it from the people who watched her. All these people in a semicircle allowing this to happen. Angel included. The one she'd asked to come and watch.

Kelly's cheeks were wet from tears and her lips wriggled in a squirmy line as she tried not to cry. That beautiful mane of gingery hair tumbled over one shoulder and hid a breast. The other breast was bare. A large and incredible teardrop tipped with a hardened nipple. She was naked to them, and from the front her pubic hair showed, a bright thatch of coppery fur. The insides

of her legs glistened. Angel wondered if it was the lubricant from the crop or was it something more?—Then cursed herself for having such a perverted thought.

The man stood fully behind her, legs shoulder width apart and astride her calves, his crotch resting behind her head. He stroked her hair, petting as he presented her to the watchful patrons. He went down on one knee behind her, caressed her shoulder, then dropped an arm. He removed the crop from her insides, tossed it where it lay on the carpet, half the shaft glistening with lubricant and Kelly's wetness.

Angel stepped back. And stepped back once more, her heel touching the wood. Practically off the carpet now. She could just pivot and leave. Walk out. *Storm* out. She'd done her part, this was over. She watched.

The handsome young men with the clean faces and tuxedos moved around, three on either side of her. The man with the demon mask leaned to take from the tabletop a black swath of fabric. He wound it between two fists then looped it over Kelly's face. She dipped her chin and accepted his blindfold. Black fabric wrapped over her eyes and nose, just her pretty mouth hanging open underneath. Once the blindfold was tied, he stroked her shoulders again with his leather gloves, then pushed her forward. She fell onto her front on the Persian rug. He put her hands behind her back, wound the chains through a metal loop on the manacles and locked it in place, the manacles holding her bound behind her back. He rolled her over so she lay facing the high ceiling and its Victorian paintings, still blinded by the black material.

As Kelly writhed on the floor, the man stood and waited, the six young men watching his held up finger. When Kelly was quiet and settled, her struggle ceasing, the man let the finger down . . .

The three young men in tuxedos put hands to their crotches, slowly drew down their zippers, the unclenching of the teeth loud in the quiet room.

Angel stepped forward again, brow lowering, bewildered by what she was seeing. She put her hand over her mouth. It looked like they would all urinate on her . . .

FROM THEIR FLIES, instead of their penises, all six of the young men withdrew a long, clear plastic tube. On the tube was a red circular valve. Each young man rotated the small plastic handles on the valve to allow fluid to pass. A stream poured from each of the young men's tubes.

She remembered the plastic corner poking out of the one man's cummerbund. It must've been an IV bag, something like you would see hanging bedside at the hospital. The fluid held in the bag, running out the hose from their zippers, warmed by their bodies, would have Kelly thinking all six men were peeing on her.

The streams splashed on Kelly's naked body. After the sound of the zippers drawing down, she fought on the floor thinking they urinated on her, jerking left and right, her big breasts bouncing and swaying. All the young men tried to aim the streams at her face. With her mouth open, she gargled, choked, spit out, then bit her lips closed trying to prevent what she thought was urine getting in her mouth. They spritzed her up and down her body now. Since her mouth was closed they picked better targets, tinkling between her legs and on her nipples. Kelly'd been holding her breath, and now let out a loud blurt, then gasped stertorous for air. The boys tried to pee in her mouth again.

Enough was enough.

Angel darted forward, stopped . . . then continued, dropped to her knees just outside the ring of men pretending to urinate on her. “Stop,” she said, “stop . . . Kelly, it’s not pee . . . they’re not peeing on you, okay?—it’s okay, it’s okay . . .”

The boys kept the hoses turned on, still sprinkling on Kelly, but there was a murmuring. All six of them wondering what to do now. Not just them, but the crowd behind her . . .

Kelly spoke, her voice a constrained squeak. “Angel . . .? It’s not . . . They’re not . . .? Don’t . . . Aw, come on . . . why would you . . .? . . . Angel, I’m okay, I . . .” Her head turned aside, like her blindfolded eyes sought out the man who’d dragged her in here by her hair. “Don’t stop . . . Don’t . . .”

It wasn’t fear or shame in Kelly’s voice. It was lust.

One young man, the one she’d eyed earlier palming his erection, lowered to a knee at the man in the demon mask’s mute instruction. The young man fished in his open fly and drew out his erection. It was a long one, thin, pointing up to the ceiling; the plumbing hose dangled under its belly flinging droplets of water. He thumbed his long erection downward till its knot end mashed Kelly’s lips. Kelly opened her mouth and the young man slid his cock inside. Kelly sucked hungrily.

Angel wiped her eyes, vision blurry with tears. She scooted back from the circle of young men. Down Kelly’s naked body, the fake urination resuming, the man with the demon mask squatted at Kelly’s feet. That awful baleful demon gaze pointed at her. Their eyes met, and she gasped. The man had stormy gray eyes under the mask, and they saw right through her. He rose first, and then she jumped up. The demon walked around the circle of young men, coming to get her . . .

She stepped back, hoping he wouldn’t pursue her.

But he came past the boys, and now she pivoted, turned around and saw the looks of disgust from the spectators—sneering at her like she'd ruined something she had no business attending in the first place.

Face buried in her hands, tears flowed more freely. She held her breath in a tight hitch and quickened her pace, heading to the door where the butler stood, steps getting quicker and quicker, and then off the carpet, her loafers clicking on the hard parquet floor . . . then she was in the mansion's hall, turning right, getting mixed up and turning right again, seeing a left and taking that . . .

Now she was in a narrower corridor, wiping at her eyes with the heels of her wrists, speed walking, wanting to get to the ballroom, get her bearings, get the hell out of here . . .

This hallway was unattended, the doors all closed. Near the end of the hallway she turned back to see if she was followed. She gasped and whimpered at the sight of a figure in black closing off the end of the hall.

All in black, wearing a cloak, a gold mask . . . but not the man. This figure was tall but not as tall as the demon. And not a demon's face. It was a woman, long legs and a lithe body that strolled her way now . . .

Angel said, "I'm leaving, okay?—you don't have to do anything . . ." Her voice was thin and tight and warbling with fear. "I'm leaving, I'm getting out of here . . ."

Still the woman strolled. Angel pivoted, heading deeper down the unattended hallway, the cherub-faced woman following behind. There was a tight knot in her stomach, and . . . and something worse, something she'd registered but ignored: Her vulva sagged like a hot, heavy mess, like an over-ripe peach had been tucked in the crotch of her panties. She squished

while she sped, bewildered, scared, ashamed, so ashamed, disgusted too, hating what she'd witnessed, but . . .

Kelly's cries of torment had done something to her that was *so* humiliating . . .

When she reached the door at the end of the hall, she pushed her body against it and yanked the lever. It didn't budge, and she collided, making it rattle. In her fear, she'd pictured opening this door and tumbling out to a garden where there was a dance party, and Abby and India would see her, grab her and all three of them would flee through the ballroom, get their phones, call for help . . .

She surrendered, rested her forehead against the door then turned and pushed her back against it. The woman approached in no hurry, lean hips swaying.

Angel started to cry. It was inexplicable. Everything all falling apart at the same time.

The woman stopped six feet out with her arms to the sides, almost a religious or saintly pose. She looked up to the mask, the placid pouted baby angel face. Behind the mask the woman's eyes hid in black.

Angel stepped slowly, slunk to the woman, and the woman closed her arms around her. Angel put her cheek against the woman's chest and the woman stroked her hair . . .

10

salon

THE WOMAN WHO LED HER DOWN ANOTHER HALL BY HER HAND HAD an elegant grace; long-limbed, thin, with narrow shoulders, and easy, nimble movements. Angel told the woman, “I’m not here for anything, please . . .”

But the woman didn’t heed. Her grip was gentle, and Angel could have pulled free, but feared such a bold move would bring chagrin; and what would chagrin bring—punishment? She saw what happened here in the mansion, so she allowed herself to be led deeper into the belly of the historic home, along the dark-stained wood-paneled hallway gleaming with lacquer; even above the wainscoting where the wall was painted a blood-red the paint gleamed with thick luster. Small paintings lined the walls, framed in heavy gold, foggy pastoral scenes that reminded her of James Whistler.

“I have friends here with me,” she said, then considered how weird that was to say. It sounded like someone so frightened they warned a predator there were witnesses before any horrendous crime could be committed. But what harm would come to her? These people at the mansion seemed as though they all offered consent; it’s not like she would be taken into a back room and tortured and dismembered. The guests at the mansion were just into some frighteningly kinky sex. But what if . . . ?

“Please, ma’am, I should stay with my friends . . .”

The woman turned her head now, gold gleaming dully on the cherubic mask, the woman raising a finger to the mask’s pouted lips, a soft shushing behind the golden mouth; the first sound the woman had made.

Angel’s fingers stiffened in the woman’s leather grip. A fine leather, buttery and supple. Any more protestation was moot now as the woman stopped at her destination, a heavy wooden door painted glossy black, a large brass doorknob with a key lock. The woman inserted a long clover-leaf key and unlocked the door, pushed it open, then gestured ahead, tugging Angel’s hand gently as more encouragement. Angel obeyed and protested no more, bowed her head and entered the room, the woman finally releasing her hand. The door closed behind them.

The room was a small salon with metal-potted ferns in stands, a globe that sat in a stand on wheels, two velvet high-back chairs and a small sofa with claw feet; the windows were shielded by heavy curtains in a satiny deep purple; behind the chairs a fire flickered in a small narrow brick hearth, the wooden mantle painted in black. It was a relief the room didn’t contain a wooden table poised upright where she could be tormented, nor hooded men with implements of strange sexual torture. She chewed her lower lip, turned to face the one who’d guided her into this peaceful place of reprieve.

The woman crossed the room, headed to a walnut bar in the corner—the bar waist high, a leather padded cuff around its half-moon table top, crystal decanters atop, amber fluids within. As the woman passed, her leather finger pointed to one of the velvet chairs, indicating for Angel to sit.

Angel said, “I’m not here to . . . *take part* . . . I thought, uh, thought this was a party or something . . .”

The woman paused, dipped her chin, fire light winking off the metal edge of her golden cherub mask. Two leather hands came up behind her head and worked to unfasten the mask's straps. At the back of her head, the woman's long gleaming black hair had been tightened into an elaborate bun with braids, two metal sticks plucked into the weave. The mask was removed, held in the cup of a palm and the woman turned to face her.

A flood of instant relief washed up from Angel's toes—she knew the woman, *respected* the woman. Then it was all dashed with instant shame at being caught here. Then terror: could she be expelled from Morrison for being found in such a house of iniquity? . . . For the woman who'd walked her into this room was Grace Chen, her professor of U.S. History, standing now, a slight smirk tugging her glossy red lips to one side, her black and deeply knowing eyes watching her.

Angel whispered the woman's name, calling her Professor Chen, her voice a thin, airy sound of disbelief. She stepped back, bottomlessly embarrassed to be seen in this house by someone she respected.

Professor Chen's smirk widened, a quiet wet lip sound now as her smile pulled enough to flash white teeth. She said, "Your last name escapes me, but I want to say you're called Angel."

At first, when her last name escaped the Professor, there was hope she could leave this room unnamed, drop out of U.S. History and avoid the woman forever, but it wasn't to be. And she wasn't a liar. She confessed: "Yes, ma'am. Angel Parker." She dipped her chin, lowered her eyes.

"That's right," Professor Chen said, her voice a clear and soft singsong. Grace Chen was one of Morrison's most respected scholars, though a new arrival to their faculty. A former corporate lawyer in Boston, she'd moved on to writing and teaching; she'd written a half-dozen history books, some on the Chinese experience in America, though not all, and had penned most

recently “The Yellow Peril,” a Pulitzer runner-up on the Burlingame Treaty and the years until the Chinese Exclusion Act. “I want to say . . . you wrote the essay on the ACS and Liberia. Was that you?”

Angel nodded, embarrassment deepening; acknowledgement of her three-thousand word essay juxtaposed with her discovery at a disgusting sex party.

“Insightful,” Professor Chen said.

“Thank you,” she said, riled that her essay had been remembered amongst hundreds—though she’d received an A and not the A-plus she’d wanted.

Escape seemed impossible now: she’d been identified, pin-pointed . . . *exposed*. “I should go, Professor Chen, I’m sorry,” she said, her body already fleeing—her mind’s eye picturing a cartoon cutout of her figure posed in sprinting stride blown out through the wall—but still her feet stayed planted on the Oriental rug and she waited for her professor’s permission.

Professor Chen studied her, brows lowering, like Angel was a curiosity. She removed a glove by plucking up on the fingers. “Go where, Miss Parker?”

She didn’t know where; back to the dorm, golly, maybe all the way back home to Illinois and burrow under the covers of her childhood bed, get under that comfy quilt. She got to the point, head turned aside, afraid to look the woman in the eye as she asked, “Am I in trouble?” Her voice was fragile, like thin glass.

“Trouble for what, Miss Parker?”

Now her head swiveled to face her professor. “For being here.”

Professor Chen’s brows huddled lower over her beautiful black eyes, still narrowed in scrutiny. She’d tugged off both gloves, held them in one hand,

that hand now poised on a cocked hip. One brow raised high. “Trouble for being here . . .? Hasn’t it occurred to you I’m the one who’d be embarrassed to be discovered in this place by a student?”

“No,” she admitted, her own brows lowering. Why hadn’t she thought of that? . . . This mansion was the adult world, and Grace Chen was an adult; but she was a young woman from rural Illinois, only newly a woman (though she doubted it herself sometimes), and a considerable woman like Grace Chen made adult choices that someone like Angel should never challenge. Plus, there was another matter: It was her own shame that occluded seeing this situation from Professor Chen’s perspective. Shame at the arousal she’d felt while watching that man abuse Kelly . . .

“Miss Parker . . .?” Angel raised eyes to see Professor Chen watching her with an expression of restrained mirth. “Am *I* in trouble?”

“Oh no,” she babbled, “No, I would never—”

Professor Chen raised a hand to silence her. “I know I’m not. I removed my mask because I trust you.”

“Trust me?” The professor didn’t even *know* her . . .

Professor Chen said, “I know you’re not like the other girls.”

“What other girls?”

“I know I can trust you,” she said simply, not wanting to spend time elaborating, then: “May I offer you a drink?” A bare, long-fingered hand with red-painted nails presented the stocked bar in the corner.

“No, thank you.”

The professor gestured again at the high-back chair, and Angel sat, watching this lissome intellectual cross to the bar, squeak off a crystal jewel

that plunged the top of a decanter and poured herself a half-inch of amber liquid. “Are you sure, Miss Parker,” the professor said without looking her way, “this is a very fine single malt, twenty-year-old . . .”

“I’m only eighteen,” she said, adding, “almost nineteen.” Though still not of drinking age in the state of Vermont.

“A soda water? Please, I don’t want you to be empty-handed . . .”

“Yes, please,” she said, chewing her cheek lining, hands squeezing sweaty fists in her lap.

The professor returned, offered Angel a heavy crystal Old-Fashioned glass with fizzing soda water and ice, then held up her own glass of whisky as if toasting. Angel raised her glass to the standing professor, and Grace touched the rim with her glass, sending off a high crystal note, saying, “To keeping secrets, Angel.”

Angel smiled at last, repeated, “To keeping secrets,” and sipped her soda water as Grace did the same then tucked her cape behind her legs and sat on the ornately wood-trimmed sofa across from Angel, crossing one long leather-clad leg over the other.

11

secrecy

THEY SAID NOTHING A MOMENT, PROFESSOR CHEN SMILING AND studying her, sipping whisky, Angel holding the glass of soda in her lap, sipping, clearing her throat, sipping again. At last, Grace set her glass down on the side table at the sofa's arm. "I think you didn't know what kind of party this was here tonight."

"I really didn't," she was quick to say, glad Professor Chen could see her innocence in all this. "If I'd known . . ."

"You wouldn't have come?"

She shook her head no vigorously.

Grace smiled, said, "Yet you watched, served witness to a scene."

She nodded. "No, it was . . ."

When she didn't finish her sentence, not finding the descriptor she needed, the professor said, "You were curious."

She hated to admit it, but they were on friendly ground here, and the professor made her feel at ease. It was hard to say though she knew better she didn't stop that man from paddling Kelly, and it was more than unsure social protocol that had her immobile. "Yes."

Grace cocked her head. “You feel shame because you were curious?”

Not quite the curiosity, but she wouldn’t admit the other feeling what she’d witnessed roused in her. “A little.”

“That’s interesting.” Grace plucked at the leather bunching at the bend in her slender knee, continued, “If I removed the mystique of what you saw tonight, I wonder if you’d still feel shame?”

“Maybe not,” she said.

“I wonder . . .” Grace smiled, eyes narrowed to slits, like she enjoyed the small measure of control that just re-emerged between them. But it was playful, the consequences of this conflict small and harmless. She wouldn’t be expelled and sent home for not seeing past the party’s mystery. Grace’s foot bobbed up and down now, and she lounged deeper in the comfortable corner of the sofa, resting a cheek in the cup of a palm, elbow planted on the arm. “What did you think of what you witnessed?”

She inhaled, considered, exhaled. “It was scary.”

“Mm-hmm,” she nodded. “The scare is theater. No one is harmed here, but some need to be brought near that precipice to *feel* . . . Do you know what I’m saying?”

She shook her head no.

“Good. A young woman stumbling into this scene with no forewarning has no hope of deciphering its complex semiotics. These things take time. But you felt an interest, no?”

“No.”

“Are you sure?”

“What do you mean?”

“I watched you.”

Again came that feeling of exposure, of giving away a private piece of herself she wanted to hold face-down and away from others. What had the professor seen in her as she was spied witnessing that bizarre ritual? What had shown on her face? . . . Now she wished for her own cherubic mask to wear. “What did you see?”

Grace smiled, and her posture straightened—like she was roused by the question. “Oh, what a wonderful question, Miss Parker. Right to the heart . . .”

“You were watching me?”

“I watch everyone.”

From where? . . . “Tell me what this is, please,” she said, polite in her tone, and nodding her chin toward the door where they’d come in.

“You *are* curious . . .” She raised her eyebrows, leaned back again saying, “Just a party for people so inclined, this one, at this house, is annual. It’s a party—or a coming together, really—for those in need of more dynamic relationships. Ones with steep disparities in power. Willing, of course.”

“It’s about sex?”

“Far more than sex. Sex is its language. And not always. But language is only used to describe meaning.”

“What does it all mean?”

“What *does* it all mean? Exactly. Isn’t that what we all use the technology of language to discover? . . . What is it all about?”

“Are you playing with me now?”

Grace chuckled, and something about the sound tickled at her, like fingertips running along the backs of her arms. Her nipples stiffened suddenly, and she had to choke back an unwanted giggle. She leaned forward instead, set the empty soda glass on the low walnut coffee table, careful it centered on a stone coaster.

“Yes, Miss Parker,” Grace continued, “I *am* playing.”

“Can you tell me what I saw? Please . . .”

“I will be honest if you’re honest with me.”

She scratched at her neck, her feet kicked nervously. “Okay.”

“Were you interested in what you watched?”

“Interested how?”

“Aroused, Miss Parker. Aroused in any way . . .?”

She frowned, closed herself off. “No.”

“That’s disappointing.”

“Why?”

“Because I was sure it wasn’t the truth.”

Her posture sagged in the chair, hating to disappoint the woman. “I mean . . .”

“A little?”

“Yes. A little.”

“Is that closer to the truth now?”

She nodded. Repeated: “A little.” The truth was probably more than *a little*, but how would one measure that accurately, anyway? One woman’s *little* was another’s *not-at-all* . . .

“If you’re a little honest, I’ll be a little honest, too . . .”

Grace leaned forward, and Angel did the same. Only, their conversation was clipped now as the door from where they’d entered clicked then swung open. A tall man stepped in, and, before looking up to his face, she identified him just from the polished shoes and long legs that showed below the hem of his black cloak.

The man with the golden mask of the demon . . .

THE MAN LOOMED above her and she was struck with fear again, looking in the dead eyes of the Yoni demon’s face. The urge to flee seized her, but with Professor Chen lounged in the couch next to her seeming unconcerned, she waited.

The demon cocked its head, studying her much the way the professor had. “We have a guest,” a deep, resonant voice said from behind the demon’s snarled, fang-bared mouth.

Professor Chen said, “We do.”

The man hummed, cocking his head the other way now. “This one ran from me.”

Professor Chen said, “She’s timid.”

He asked Angel: “Is it the mask?”

She'd held her breath since he'd entered, and now she exhaled slowly, nodding her head.

The man put gauntlet hands behind his head, pushed back the cowl, chin dipped down, unbuckled the mask and let it fall into the cup of a large leather palm. He raised his face to her.

The man behind the demon mask was handsome, undeniably; striking in an unexpected way, a man with a large nose, and heavy brow, but with the gravitas of someone older and wealthy, one with extraordinary style. His intelligent blue-gray eyes sparkled, his dirty blonde hair brushed back from his face, thick, heavy, kept in place by product; product she could detect now; something deep and masculine, woodsy, but lightened by the civilized smell of talc and citrus. He was tanned, and despite being a man around thirty, his skin was supple and quenched. It was the face of a powerful man who was accustomed to luxury. Not at all what she'd expected.

He smiled now, showed her a devilish flash of white teeth. "Hopefully less fearsome," he said, and Professor Chen chuckled.

Angel looked Grace's way now before she succumbed to the man's strangely magnetic gaze. Of course this man and Grace were together; the costumes matched, the masks were similar, not in style but in execution; one a cherub perhaps from Roman times, the other a Yoni from a culture clear across the globe, nevertheless both seemingly made by the same artist. The professor and the demon were together.

Grace confirmed it now, saying to her, "Miss Parker, this is my husband, Baron Gravesande." Angel looked his way, Grace saying, "Baron, this is Angel Parker, a student at Morrison. One with promise."

He smiled warmly at Angel, his mask held to his chest under a forearm. "And you're interested in the scene?"

Grace answered for her. “Miss Parker wandered here by mistake.” Then to her: “How *did* you get entrance?”

She hated to rat a person out, but it didn’t seem like something needed secret. “My roommate. She had three tickets. She said she got them from a senior at school.” She held aloft her proof of entrance, presenting the gold medallion on the long flat ribbon so Baron Gravesande could see.

Grace and her husband shared a look of concern, Grace shrugging then, both of them shaking their heads.

“Is it wrong for me to be here?”

Professor Chen said, “Not at all, Miss Parker, I hope you feel welcome.”

Baron saw Angel’s empty glass and offered to refill it but she declined. Baron came around to where his wife sat on the chaise and stooped to kiss her. His large hand liberated her glass of whisky and he sat down next to her imbibing a mouthful before passing it back to Grace who set it down on the side table.

Now he crossed his arms, leaned against his wife’s shoulder, taller even though he lounged, watching Angel, but saying to Professor Chen, “Tell me about our guest.”

Professor Chen said, “Angel attends Morrison. One of my U.S. History students . . .”

He said, “Uh-oh.”

Grace said, “Angel and I are sworn to secrecy.”

Angel tried to show a friendly smile to Baron but his demanding gaze was unnerving, making her feel unsure. She clarified: “I wouldn’t say anything to anybody . . .”

Gaze still on Angel, he said to Grace, “Can we trust her?” There was a sparkling merriment in his eyes, but still, the two of them peering into her right now felt like piercing ravens’s eyes, looking down from atop a perch.

Grace waited a beat, then smiled. The act of smiling always turned her eyes to pleasant upturned black lash dashes that Angel liked to see. Professor Chen never smiled at school. She said, “I trust her.”

Baron said, “And of her friends . . .? Where are they?”

Professor Chen asked her, “Are your friends still in the mansion, Miss Parker?”

“I think so. They were dancing . . .”

Baron said, “They shouldn’t be brought here.”

Angel agreed, saying, “Oh no, sir.”

Baron’s brows raised, and he said, “I think in this atmosphere, Miss Parker, you might call me Baron.”

“Okay.”

Professor Chen smiled again, said, “And you might call me Grace.”

She nodded, and a warm feeling came up her back and she felt her cheeks blush. “You can call me Angel.”

“We’re all friends, Angel,” Baron said, and now he was smiling too, but those gray eyes flashed on her, still absorbing from her anything he could read. Her skin prickled, and her nipples budded, pressing uncomfortably inside her bra.

12

merit

GRACE SAID TO BARON, “ANGEL ATTENDS MORRISON ON *TWO* LARGE scholarships.”

“Well, well, well,” Baron said, brows rising even higher.

“You *know* that?” Angel’s voice came out even more a whisper than intended.

“I’m inspired by women with early accomplishment,” Grace said.

Baron said, “She’s a good student?”

“Excellent,” Grace said.

Baron nodded and smiled, humming in his throat. Grace exhaled through her nose a huff of a breathy laugh and put her hand on Baron’s shoulder and caressed him.

Grace said, “Reinhardt-Klein scholarship, and one for Also, I want to say something regional . . .? For sports . . .”

“Mm,” Baron hummed appreciatively, saying, “What’s your sport, Angel?”

Grace said, “Angel runs track.”

Angel's scalp tightened, and she felt the hairs at the nape of her neck try to rise. She felt exposed again, known, and her heart pumped faster.

"A real live athlete," Baron said.

"I've seen her run. She is beautiful."

"Very beautiful," Baron said.

Grace chuckled, patted her husband's shoulder, said, "Her stride, Baron, I'm referring to her stride." Then her eyes went over Angel and she said, "But, yes, she *is* beautiful."

The blush on Angel's cheeks deepened, and the whoosh-whoosh of her heart thundered in her ears. She touched nails on her neck, feeling herself squirming inside her own clothing; the attention on her was enormous, and she really wished now she *could* burst through the wall, run all the way home to Illinois. No one called her beautiful except her family, and her boyfriend—people she knew were obliged to do so. Hearing it unprompted from Grace and Baron was overwhelming. The intent was obvious to her: since she *wasn't* beautiful, they wanted something from her . . .

She tried to speak, but her voice was thick and stuck. She cleared her throat, said, "Not Division One or anything . . ."

Both Baron and Grace seemed disappointed by her answer, and she flinched, her mind desperately conjuring excuses to leave that wouldn't embarrass herself or her hosts.

Baron said, "Humble."

Grace said, "Yes." Then: "Angel, humility has value, but do not diminish your accomplishments."

“Sorry,” she said, and looked at her gathered hands in her lap, fingers intertwined, sweaty and tense.

Baron chuckled to himself, sat up, rubbed those big hands on his knees then rose to stand. He moved around behind Angel’s high-back chair, and her head oscillated to follow him. He poked at the fire, got the glowing logs rotated so they hissed and popped. He added two more logs.

Grace said to her, “Angel, come sit with me,” and patted the spot next to her where Baron had been sitting.

Despite hesitation, she did as she was told, rising, moving to the sofa and sitting a foot apart from Grace. Now they both faced the door to the hall, and she had to swivel so she could see Grace who still lounged comfortably snake like, insinuated in the corner of the sofa, the black of her cloak, leather, and gleaming hair stark against the pale rose-printed Chinoiserie fabric. Up close like this she could see the unblemished perfection of her professor’s skin, and smell the soft but deep scent of her perfume, a light bergamot overtop a heavy sandalwood.

Grace said, “I was telling you the nature of the party beyond the safety of our door.”

“You were . . .”

Behind her, Baron said, “If you weren’t expecting it, I imagine what you saw tonight could be quite shocking.”

It was an enormous understatement. Angel turned to see him, but he was passing behind the sofa, heading to the bar. His hand came near Angel’s shoulder but ran over Grace instead. As he poured himself a glass of the same single malt, Grace said, “I think our young guest was rattled.” While she spoke to her husband, her eyes were on Angel, and as their gaze met Grace did one of those smiles that made Angel feel happy.

“I bet,” Baron said, squeaking home the crystal into the mouth of the decanter.

“But it aroused something within her,” Grace continued, betraying her.

“Professor Chen,” she scolded in a quiet whisper.

“Oh, it’s all right, Angel,” Grace said, touching her arm now, holding her just above her wrist.

“Don’t be shy,” Baron said, nonchalant, unbothered, sipping whisky.

Red blazed on her cheeks, she was sure of it, the heat raced her skin, even the tops of her ears went warm.

“Aw, she’s blushing,” Grace said, then seeing the expression of fear on Angel’s face, corrected herself. “I mean no harm, Angel. There was a time I attended my first party and I remember fondly the heart-dropping charge I got watching for the first time.”

“It was a lot,” she said, running hair behind her ear, manufacturing good humor, not wanting to insult her hosts with her awkwardness and easy offense. She wanted them to be sure she was a worldly young woman.

“The party tonight is for consenting adults who all share certain proclivities. Disparities—”

“In power . . .”

Grace appreciated the input, stroking Angel’s arm, saying, “That’s right, just as I said. There are those who like to dominate—”

Baron said, “And those who like to submit.”

Angel said, “And sex is just the language?”

Baron frowned, having missed the earlier conversation.

Grace said, “Angel, do you have a boyfriend?”

“Yes.”

There was a look of disappointment on Grace and Baron’s faces, and Angel corrected herself. “No. I mean no.” When Baron frowned and Grace cocked her head, Angel said. “It’s complicated . . .”

“Tell me,” Grace said, the softness of her voice not disguising a certain eagerness that reminded Angel of her friends when they had sleepovers—which was weird because she couldn’t imagine Grace ever at a sleepover. Or as a kid, really. She was woman with a capital W.

Angel said, “He *was* my boyfriend, but I broke up with him before college.”

“Where are you from?”

“Illinois. I broke up with him, but he doesn’t believe me.”

“Doesn’t believe you?”

“He says we’re still together.”

“But you’re not?”

She shook her head no.

“Where does he go to school?”

“He works. He’s taking a year off.”

“He’s at home?”

Angel nodded. “In Illinois.”

Grace looked behind her to Baron. “She *is* timid.”

Baron nodded, walked behind them to come around the chaise. Angel said to Grace, “I told him. I told him we needed a break . . .”

“And he didn’t accept it?”

Baron sat down next to her, and his weight on the sofa was noticeable; she tilted toward him. She looked to Baron.

Baron said, “Disregarded it, I imagine.”

“Yeah,” she said. “Yes.”

Baron said, “What’s his name?”

“Brian.”

Grace said, “You have an energy that draws a strong hand.”

“I do?”

“I feel it,” Baron said.

Grace said, “Does Brian have a strong hand?”

She shrugged.

Baron touched her shoulder with the point of his index finger, getting her to look into his steel eyes. “Is he good to you?”

She shrugged again, mouth swishing around, temples getting tight as her jaw flexed.

Grace said quietly, “I think Brian is a subject for another time. But it’s fair to say you’re not in a relationship . . .”

Angel said, “I think he’s going to propose to me. At Christmas . . .”

There was a beat of quiet, and Grace patted her arm. “Let’s talk about the party.”

Baron said, “You fled.”

She recalled the scene; Baron an unknown masked man in black, menacing Kelly with a crop, snapping it against her bare ass and the backs of her thighs, her cries of pain, her pleading for him to stop, the frightening man penetrating her with the butt of the crop, blindfolding her, those men looking like they would urinate on her . . . Only, now she was sitting next to the man, and the man wasn’t frightful, he was handsome and charming. Without his mask, he didn’t provoke the terror she’d felt earlier. And the act of the young men urinating on Kelly was a trick, a sleight of hand. They didn’t do it, only made her believe they did. Was it possible it had all been for Kelly’s own benefit? Were it Baron’s, what would stop him from having them actually perform the disgusting deed? . . .

“That woman, she said her name was Kelly, she wanted me to watch . . .”

He raised his chin, a pleasant look to his face still, unbothered and patient to hear the rest.

“She was in pain . . .”

“I imagine she was,” he said, still waiting.

“She . . . begged for you to stop . . .”

“And I didn’t,” he said, like he was proud.

Grace rubbed the back of Angel’s arm, and now she turned back to the professor. Grace said, “The woman didn’t want him to stop.”

“You didn’t hear her . . .”

“The woman he was with was still in control of that scenario.”

“She was manacled, chained . . .”

“The woman still had control, Angel,” Grace said, and her tone and manner had Angel believing. Not understanding, but at least convinced.

Baron said, “Her begging me to stop might have been the part she most anticipated.”

“She knew you would whip her?”

“It’s what she wanted. I’d surmise she was anxious all week for tonight, excited knowing what would come . . .”

“All week?”

Grace said, “Baron had made arrangements with her beforehand. They have to feel each other out, work over how the scenario will benefit both of them, but not delve too deep into detail lest the thrill be lessened.”

Baron said, “I’d arranged an elaborate ruse for my sub, but it proved too much for young Angel. She interjected . . .”

“I’m so sorry, really . . .”

Baron said, “You must be familiar with the phrase: safe word. I feel it’s in the vernacular now.”

“Yeah,” she said. “Like a codeword to stop.”

Grace said, “When she screamed for him to stop, the intent of those words is moot. It’s true expression, a human reaction to what a man like Baron may deliver. Amplified, too, in her own head. Her fantasy of what Baron may be. One thing for sure: Had she uttered whatever word she’d arranged with Baron beforehand, their safe word, the scenario would have ceased.”

“Our experiences are safe ones,” Baron said, touching her shoulder again with the point of his finger.

Grace asked her, “Do you feel more at ease?”

“I guess,” she said, nodding, looking down at the coffee table. Some of the mystery had been brushed aside, but she still couldn’t understand how a woman would arrange beforehand to be treated that way. Then again, one of the other things she didn’t understand was her own personal reaction to what she witnessed. She wasn’t aware of their arrangement, Baron and Kelly, and yet once she watched the woman’s torture, she felt a profound attraction to the noises the woman made; the pleading, the begging . . . The notes the woman sang had a melody that resonated. The song roused something inside.

Grace whispered, “What were your feelings when you watched Baron deliver the punishment?” Her hand stroked Angel’s arm reassuringly.

Angel hugged herself, arms around arms, wedged between two daunting and beautiful human beings, staring past the points of her knees at nothing. “I don’t know . . .”

“I’d love to hear what you thought, if you’re willing to tell me . . .” Grace ran a gently clawed hand up and down her arm, fingernails dragging over her wool sweater. Her nipples tried to roll over in her bra but snagged. She fidgeted uncomfortably, tugged her bra straps trying to be discreet.

“Don’t squirm, Angel, that’s your body fighting your mind. I’d like to listen, if you’d like to divulge . . .”

“It wasn’t bad . . .” Though she spoke quietly her voice sounded loud in the room, her confession booming over the hiss and pop of the small fire.

“It was good,” Baron said, his voice deep and so near.

“I don’t know about good,” she said, frowning, still staring at nothing.

Grace said, “When I was introduced, my first reaction was astounding fear. But to say I wasn’t excited by the spectacle would be a lie . . .”

13

absolution

ANGEL DIDN'T ANSWER, SAT TRYING TO SWALLOW WITH A THROAT that had gone bone dry.

Baron said, "For some it is natural to be excited. We all have our roles in the theater you watched tonight. Did you identify with the crop or with the willing flesh?"

Her eyes widened. "I . . ."

Grace said, "There are those who are dominant and those who are submissive. I believe from what I know of you, you identify with the woman you saw crop-punished by my husband's hand . . ."

Answering seemed impossibly embarrassing; her heart pounded again, neck swollen and tight, eardrums being played by the thunder of her pulse. She half-faced Baron, afraid to meet his gaze so close. "You . . . you're dominant?"

Grace answered for him: "Very."

In her periphery she was aware Baron smiled. She faced Grace. Grace said now, "I am as well."

She nodded, lowered her eyes. “So you . . . don’t do that stuff to each other . . .?”

Baron said, “We need the submissive.”

Before she turned to face Baron, Grace said, “We’re in desperate need of the *right* girl . . .”

It was all so obvious . . . though she’d seen it coming a mile away, now it was confirmed.

She rose to stand, and neither of her hosts prevented her. She’d anticipated hands grabbing her, yanking her down, the two of them tearing at her clothes to find bare flesh they could punish.

When she turned to face them, her nipples had gone to stones, hard and uncomfortable. Grace and Baron were unperturbed, watching her patiently, Grace with a cheek in a palm, smiling, Baron smiling too, large hands on knees.

The desire to flee was strong; the desire to stay stronger. She stood dumbly staring at them, saying nothing.

Grace said, “You feel shame for how you felt watching the punishments.”

She nodded. Her hands had nothing to do, and she didn’t know where to put them; not in her pockets, not on her hips . . . she gathered them below her waist and wound her fingers together.

Baron said, “Do you feel guilt, Angel?”

“I guess . . .”

No one said anything for a moment, the absence of voices making Angel want to scream out. The tension wound tight and thin. A log popped.

Grace said, “Perhaps a small punishment may absolve you of your sins.”

She sucked her lower lip right under her teeth, eyes wide, staring at Grace’s thin, leather-clad knees.

Baron said, “Are your friends expecting you?”

The question was strange, and she raised her gaze to meet his. “Yes . . .”

Grace’s pointed boot bobbed again, one long leg crossed over the other. She said, “Take out your phone and let them know you’re okay. Tell them you’ve gone home already and you’ll see them later.”

“It’s all locked up.”

Grace nodded her chin toward the table. “Pass it near that gray thing, it’ll unlock.”

On the table, very near where she’d set her glass on the coaster, and buttressed by overhanging flowers from a central bouquet, was a dull gray plastic *thing* that looked like an oversized juicer.

Without hesitation, she withdrew her phone from the pocket of her skirt, brought it near the juicer, and, sure enough, a small click told her the pouch was unlocked. She withdrew her phone, hand shaking. There was a notification of a message from her mother and she swiped it away before she could read it.

Baron said, “We’ll arrange for you a ride home.” Adding: “You’re safe with us.”

She met his steely gaze, him looking up at her through his heavy handsome brow. The eyes were cold, but they were truthful.

She sent a message to India.

Angel: sorry had to bail see you back at dorm

She stood with the phone at her waist, all three of them waiting for her roommate's response. Her phone dinged. India must be out of the mansion.

India: get freaked out?

She responded yes, Grace and Baron watching her.

India: don't blame u this place is crazy

India: Abs and I going crazy looking for you

India: how u getting home?

She texted: I'm in an Uber.

India: u message me when u get to Roth

She chewed her lip, watching her hosts. Texted.

Angel: I will

The phone went back in her pocket, and her hands went together again, fingers wringing against one another.

Baron said, "That's a good girl." She loved the look in his eyes.

Grace said, "I think you'd like to know a punishment."

She shrugged, wanted to look away, lowered her eyes again to her hosts's shoes.

Baron said, "It will clear the guilt from you."

Grace said, "Or make it worse."

Baron smiled, said, "Would you like to find out?"

Now she stayed facing them but looked back over her shoulder at the black door that would take her into the hall, out to the rooms where the punishments happened, to the gallery, to the foyer, to the fresh air of night. She turned back to regard them, eyes low.

Grace's soft voice: "I'd like to see your legs."

She swallowed her lower lip again, but stood motionless.

"If you'd like to show them," Grace said.

Angel slid forward one loafer, the sole scratching the fine wool of the Oriental rug. With her toe pointed, she presented one leg to them, flexing it, looking aside and chewing her cheek.

Baron said, "Without your tights."

"Oh," she said, fingers wringing tighter. She looked over her shoulder at the door again.

Grace said, "You may leave if you wish."

"Yeah," she whispered, looked at them, then back at the door. She pinched the knit fabric of her tights mid-thigh, just above the hem of her skirt, tugged till they got to her hips. She see-sawed, got the waistband lower, then slipped her hands inside and pushed them to her knees.

Baron said, "Your shoes, too."

With her tights bunched at her knees, showing her hosts a flash of thigh, she pried off her loafers with her toes, then bent and pushed the tights to her ankles, stepped on them and pulled her feet out. Now she stood barefoot, in skirt, sweater, and shirt.

"Such beautiful legs," Baron said.

Grace said, “You should see her run.”

“I’d love to.”

Grace said, “Flex them again for us.”

Angel held out her foot, showed them her bare leg, pointed her toes and tightened her sore muscles.

“You’re incredible,” Baron said.

Her cheeks blazed, her heart raced. She murmured, “I have such a weird body.”

Grace and Baron looked shocked. Grace said, “Why would you say that?”

“I don’t look like other girls.”

“Your body is *your* body, and you treat it with respect. Your mind is sharp and clear. You are at the precipice of becoming a powerful woman.”

That made her smile and she couldn’t help it. Coming from a woman like Grace Chen the compliment was enormous and valuable. If she could have the stature of a woman like that . . .

Now she tucked tentative fingers under the hem of her skirt, slowly dragged the hemline higher, up past mid-thigh, a sudden raw *sexual* feeling suppurating in the bottom of her stomach like a piece of rotting fruit. She exhaled a ghostly moan. Baron and Grace watched what she revealed, obviously rapt.

Grace said, “Unzip your skirt.”

Angel complied, drawing down the loud zip at the side of her black wool skirt. She knew what came next, and without being told she let the skirt

lower to her knees then dropped it in a hoop around her ankles. She stood before them hands covering the front of her cotton underwear.

Baron ran a finger in a slow helicopter motion like he'd done for Kelly, indicating to turn around. Angel turned, shuffling in place, her dropped skirt tangling on her feet. When she faced the door to the hall, she put a foot back and flexed her calves, looking over her shoulder to see their reaction. The appreciation on their faces excited her. It was thrilling to be acknowledged, but more thrilling to see her hosts satisfied. She wanted them pleased with her.

Baron said, "Lift your shirt for us, please."

She swallowed with effort, felt behind her how her shirt tail hung below her sweater, covering her bottom. Between thumb and finger, she slowly raised the hanging shirt to show them her ass, the whole while chewing on her top lip, sawing teeth over the plump flesh till it hurt.

"Up on your toes," Baron said now. She did as requested, went up on her toes and flexed her legs again.

She heard Grace whisper, "Oh, she is exquisite," and turned to see Grace sidling up next to her husband, holding his arm as she marveled at what Angel revealed.

"Face us," Baron said, and she went to her heels again, let go her shirt and turned their way, head down, hands clasped.

"And your sweater, Angel," Grace said.

She paused before she crossed arms, pulled up the front of her sweater, then over her head with a static snap in her hair. She stood before them, her sweater still sleeve-stuck on one arm, hanging down and grazing her toe tips.

Baron mimed the act of undoing shirt buttons, saying, “Your shirt too, Angel.”

She unbuttoned one, then the next down, hands pausing on the third. “I . . . Can I keep my shirt on?”

They stared at her without expression. She shifted her weight from one foot to the other, nervously chewing her cheek. “That’s all right, Angel,” Grace said.

There was disappointment there, and she didn’t like seeing it in the married couple’s eyes. She parted the shirt’s front tails, showing them the highest of her thighs, her hips, her underwear, looking down then, feeling embarrassed and saying, “I wish I didn’t wear bright blue underwear,” and gave a weird giggle. They didn’t laugh along, staring at her with an intensity she liked. Now in an uncomfortable whisper: “Blue doesn’t go . . . with my . . . skin, uh, tone . . .” They disregarded her non sequitur, watching with blazing interest. “I should have . . . I should have worn black, I guess.” Still no input from them. “It wasn’t, um, clean . . .”

Baron said, “Angel, get on your knees.”

THE COMMAND WAS what she’d wanted, but didn’t know till she heard those words in Baron’s deep and masculine voice. There was a strange relief in being given a command. It removed choice, and sometimes choice led her to awkward immobility. Plus, it brought Baron and Grace pleasure for her to submit, and she found the act of pleasing them warmed her insides.

“Yes, sir,” she said—because she wanted to say it. It felt *good* to say it.

And, oh, the look on Baron and Grace's faces when she did. The flash in their eyes, the swelling of their chests . . .

Now she lowered, eyes on theirs, her left knee giving a quiet pop as she squatted low, then dropped to her knees before them at the front of the couch.

Grace said, "Come closer to us."

She whispered, "Okay," and knee-walked two steps to come to the couch, posed between Baron and the professor, looking up at them expectantly.

Grace said, "How do you want your punishment?"

She froze, not knowing how to answer. "I don't know . . ."

Baron said, "You're not ready for the crop." A statement, not a question.

"I . . . I don't think so," she admitted.

"Take Baron's hand," Grace said, and she wove her slender fingers between her husband's large ones, lifted his hand closer to Angel.

She looked to both of their faces, both of them patiently watching down on her, but a simmering excitement in their eyes. Her fingers stroked over the hand presented to her. More than twice the size of one of her own hands. Baron had beautiful hands. Large and perfectly masculine; well-groomed, the skin soft and supple but the hand obviously strong. He had *powerful* hands. The knuckles were large and pronounced, the fingers thick, long. The hand was his left, and a gold wedding band shone on his ring finger. She caressed his hand, the hand presented to her like a loose fist, the knuckles facing her, reminding her of a religious figure expecting a ring to be kissed.

Slowly, Baron's hand opened flat, and his palm was presented to her. She stroked his hand lightly, tracing the edges of his extended thumb now, the bowed shape, the bulging walnut of a joint. Her right palm slipped along his, their two outstretched hands spread like starfish, mating up, the size difference laugh inducing.

Grace said, "Baron has beautiful hands, doesn't he?"

"Yes," she whispered.

Baron's hand closed to a loose fist again, rising toward her, and now she did press her lips to it, not kissing, but wanting to feel the hardness of his bones against the softness of her lips.

Baron said, "Will this stir trauma?"

"What . . .?"

He turned over his own hand, showed his palm, his eyes moving to it, hers following. He said, "The discipline."

What he intended seemed obvious now. Grace said, "Will this bring up memories you want to leave forgotten?"

"Oh," she said, "no . . . I was never punished, I . . . I was a good girl . . ."

That pleased them. Grace said, "I have no doubt you were," leaning closer, touching Angel's neck, then her soft hand cupping her cheek, long thumb stroking gently under Angel's eye. "I want you to put your tummy over my husband's knee."

14

the rising tide

THIS WAS A PIVOTAL MOMENT OF CHOICE, ONE WHOSE ENORMITY would remain with her even out of this room. There was no confinement, no force, only what she could identify as a careful manipulation of her own burgeoning curiosity. And though never in her life could she ever have predicted a moment such as this, she wasn't deterred. She was a young woman raised in a small, clean, safe rural home. Brought up in a household with a mother and father, both kind and loving; she had two sisters with whom she frequently fought but who she also loved desperately. But now she was alone in a room with an enigmatic scholar and intellectual, and that woman's mysterious but gorgeous husband; a room from another era, like she was transported in time; a small finely furnished space with antique handmade furniture; expensive fabrics, expensive appointments; out of her element by a rural mile. . . . A fire crackled, she was warm; she was safe—and yet her heart hammered, her pulse raced, her mind sputtered with the provocative adrenalin spike of fight or flight.

Now she rose from her knees, standing bottomless before her professor, clad only in a partly buttoned shirt, a bra and panties. Her gaze fell downward, down her bared legs and feet, the parts of her she wasn't embarrassed to show.

Grace watched her patiently, black eyes narrowed, bright red lips held in soft amusement; Baron sat expectantly, large frame reclined in the sofa, legs apart, hands on thighs, his eyes on hers, waiting to see what she would choose.

This time she didn't toss a fearful look over her shoulder to make sure her escape exit still existed. The black door to the hall would still be there and these two wouldn't prevent her from going through it, she believed.

Lips sucked between her teeth she committed to what was requested.

Baron brought his legs closer together as she made her intention known, shuffling where she stood to face Grace's husband. The firmness in his eyes flickered with excitement, but the man kept it at bay, not gushing, smiling, or slapping his thigh. She knew where he wanted her—and now she lowered, curled herself onto his lap, her stomach and breasts pressing the rocky hardness of his long, muscular legs.

The act of overt submission squeezed a slow gasping exhale from her lungs, and her eyes widened. Stretched over Baron's lap, her view now showed the small blazing fire roiling in the brick hearth, flame-light flickering orange on the glossy wooden edges of the couch's arm, the end table, and one of the high-back chairs.

Warm hands stroked the front sides of her naked shins, making her stomach tighten, and her nipples too, Grace touching her legs, collecting them, raising her off the floor; she was laid over Baron's thighs, her feet hooked over Grace's. The shirt tail was peeled over the small of her back, and she could feel the air against her bottom, exposed now for both of them to see. She chewed her lip, eyes narrowing.

Baron said, "You'll need a safe word."

"Yeah," she whispered, eyes fluttering open.

He said, "The house words tonight are Wind and Haven. Said together they will be your safety. Do you understand, Angel?"

"Yes," she said, her whisper tight and warbling.

Grace's singing voice: "Wind Haven, Angel. Do you understand?" Fingers traced up the backs of her bare thighs and a wild tickle raced through her, getting her squirming against Baron's legs.

"Yes," she gasped, squeezing her stomach to force the air out of her seizing lungs.

Baron's voice: "Yes, Mistress," correcting her. Now a huge warm hand settled on her haunch. Baron's power traveled through their connection, the sheer weight of his man's hand on her, merely resting.

"Yes, Mistress," she repeated, bewildered by the words coming out of her own mouth.

The large hand circled her bottom, going around three times, Baron's hand larger than her ass; fingers tucked into the back of her underwear's waistband and the first urge to flee slammed her. She jolted and half-twisted, looking to stop him. Grace cuddled her feet and shushed her. She right-faced, saw Baron watching her.

"Face down, sub."

"Sub?"

"Face down," he repeated.

She obeyed. Position returned, she watched the fire again through narrowed eyes, dragged her elbows over Baron's thigh, her right one resting on the sofa's seat, the other hooking against the side of Baron's knee. Her breasts

squashed against him, and her hard, budded nipples hurt. She wished now she'd removed her bra from inside her shirt.

The fingers tugged gently against the waistband, Baron murmuring, "Up," and her arching her back, sticking out her butt, letting her professor's husband peel down her panties.

"Oh my God," she whispered to the fire, feeling her ass being bared, her panties scrolling over her ass flesh, and tugging down her thighs.

Baron's hand warmed circles on her bare ass now, and her eyes rolled up at the outrageous feel. Grace must have taken over her underwear removal because beyond the large hand smoothing her ass there was the feel of cotton sliding down her thighs and over her knees to her ankles.

The hand patted a warning. Then two more. She squirmed again, her thighs tightening, knees grinding into one another. Grace caressed her feet . . .

The first strike against her bare ass took her breath away. She yipped, jolted, dug her elbows into Baron's leg. She bit her lips to swallow the sound she'd made. In her ears still echoed the slap of Baron's large hand against her bare ass. No more smacks came, and she exhaled in slow chugs, her mind suddenly alert and electric, her ears tuned to the sounds of the—

Whack. Another perfect strike against her ass, and she called out loud and bright. "Oh, ow, mm," she whimpered and moaned.

But as her legs began to writhe, a flurry of open hand strikes rained on her bottom, losing count at four, a total of six or seven rang out, maybe even more, hard flesh against soft flesh, her thighs shaking, her ass bouncing.

"Ow, ha, ah, ow," she complained, struggling in Baron's lap. Grace held her ankles in place as she tried to kick, and now Baron slithered his forearm under Angel's chin, his hand tucking over the back of her shoulder and

pinning her onto his lap. Being held like that encouraged a struggle from her, wagging her hips, her bottom, shimmying her legs—it brought another salvo of slaps on her hurting ass. Over and over the slaps came loud and sharp, each one a shock up her back, shooting stars into her cranium, and she wailed, “Stop, ow, okay, okay, ow, please, stop . . .”

And pleading had never felt so incredible.

He slapped again, harder. And she babbled for him to stop again, knowing he wouldn’t unless he heard their arranged phrase. She begged him to stop fervently, a wild rushing pleasure in her pounding heart, loving the sound of her own pleading.

Baron slowed, his hand caressing her. She whimpered into his forearm, her lips mushing against the fabric of his suit jacket. “There, there, pet,” he said, voice low and quietly rumbling.

He said something aside to Grace, but Angel was unable to decipher it. Grace whispered a reply, and not knowing what they discussed had Angel worrying, her toes scrunching, her hips rolling against Baron’s thigh.

Her ass burned now. The cheeks felt cold on the surface but a heat blazed inside, hot racing sheets up the backs of her thighs, and throbbing in her buttocks. She struggled in his lap again and was unsure why. Not to get away—because no one held her in place. But now all she could think of was the tight knot of anticipation low in her belly. That’s what she writhed against—the knot’s discomfort. Only, moving did nothing to alleviate it; every position she took did nothing to abate the steady interior thrum. It was like dread, like her stomach had an important appointment it’d missed and now only remembered. She panted at the uncomfortable feeling, turning her rump up higher like another strike of Baron’s huge masculine hand might chase it away.

No strike came, and now she felt the tips of his fingers tracing the shapes and curves of her ass. She stuck her rump up higher despite the shame her split would be exposed; there was a chance they could see her most intimate places. That knowledge only tightened the feeling inside her, made it worse. She considered asking for another strike—

Baron's fingers grazed near her core. Her scalp tightened, and she drew in a deep breath and held it. He wouldn't touch her there . . . But now she poked her ass out more, looking for touch . . .

"Oh God, oh my God," she exhaled at the feel of this man's fingers slipping along her private place turned up like this so her professor could see. She whimpered and closed her eyes realizing what the lightness of his touch meant; she was wet. And from the feel of his exploring fingers now, she was more than wet, she was sopping. "Oh God, oh, wow, oh," she said worming her stomach against him, marveling at the measure of relief from the discomfort the touch of his fingers against her outer labia brought.

Oh God, they were talking again, Grace and Baron. She heard the whispered words Punishment and Wet and knew they discussed what the spanking had brought out from inside her. Her chin lifted, and she struggled to turn but Baron lifted his arm, forcing her right shoulder high and preventing her.

"Don't," she said, but still he teased his touch along her slick opening. It was deeply embarrassing, and now this event had taken a dark turn she didn't like. There was shame in her body's reaction.

The tip of his finger stroked high, slipping off the yoke of her sex membranes, tugging the tight banjo string of flesh between her vagina and anus; then circled the pucker of her sphincter. She kicked her feet, jumping at the wild, invasive feel of it.

“Please, don’t do that,” she said, wanting him to stop, but then again, knowing she wasn’t ready to utter the phrase he assured would make him cease. She kicked her feet again, felt her ankles held by Professor Chen, and Baron tightened his grip against her shoulders under her chin, making sure she wouldn’t try to roll on his lap like a crocodile.

“Don’t touch me there,” she pleaded. But telling them that only highlighted what was affecting her. If she truly wanted them to stop, she would say Wind Haven . . .

The fingers stroked again, up and down, strong and stiff, her flesh supple and well-greased. The more Baron stroked, the more her eyes tried to tug upward, wanting to roll in her head; her mouth fell open, and she dug her nails into the tight weave of the couch’s fabric.

Softer hands caressed her now; *three* hands smoothing her ass, the backs of her thighs. It was Grace’s hands exploring her haunches, surely getting a good look between her legs, too, those beautiful black eyes of hers poring over her sexual opening . . .

“Ohh,” Angel moaned in an awful quavering warble. The salacious thrill knowing she was exposed and examined, sexually studied by these two dominant individuals, was overwhelming. Her tummy tightened against Baron’s hard thigh and now she could feel a spate gushing anew from her, and his stroking fingers returned, slipping through her spilling juices and pleasuring the furred membranes of her opening.

She started to buck against him uncontrollably and her thighs trembled—she was sure they visibly shook. It was like a deep winter chill had settled into her bones, her autonomous system firing up her twitch muscles . . . Only she blazed with heat, not stiffened with cold. A fire burned in her core, low, beneath her organs; a desperate *need* radiating from that hard and hurting sexual knot tightening inside her like wet rope.

“Puh-please . . .” she whispered so quiet she couldn’t be heard. But it wasn’t the sound of pleading for reprieve, now she begged for more, begged for release, begged for that lusty hurting knot to be untied . . .

The flat of his large palm smoothed the centre valley of her parted ass cheeks, wetting his skin against the eager membranes that cushioned her entrance, and someone mewled a low catlike sound. It was her, and now profound shame flickered up like a fading fire had found new fuel.

“Oh, no, don’t,” she said quiet, but her hips seeking more pressure, humping against his touch. And when he stroked her boldly, applying wicked force to her malnourished sex, she moaned another girlish sound that mortified her. She rubbed her cheek on his leg, then her lips, finally clenching his pants’s fabric between her teeth, pressing down her knees to drive her ass higher.

The fingers stroked from the front (where the pleasure was wild to the point of obliteration), along her groove where something inside her howled like wind in a cavern, then coming up like they would leave, encouraging her tummy to lift right off his thigh, her sex following her master’s hand, not wanting him gone yet . . .

As he conjured her higher, the fingers reversed direction and together she and her master brought him inside her body.

“Aww,” she cried, being penetrated. There was discomfort, like he’d put his whole hand inside her, though she knew it couldn’t be more than two fingers, and she gnashed her teeth on his pant leg, and her hand snatched a handful of soft material that had to be a bundle of his cloak.

Whatever drilled inside her went with ease despite the size; she was well-greased, and it passed into her body without hitching. She kicked her feet, saying, “Stop, oh, okay, ow, mm, please, no . . .”

And without uttering her special words, Baron obeyed her.

He stopped. His finger paused inside her tight canal, her muscles rippling against the object imbedded in her, and the more she squeezed against it, the warmer she felt and the less strange the intrusion.

With venerable bewilderment, Baron whispered to Grace: “She’s intact.”

The light and airy words were heavy with tenor.

Angel moaned a sound of humiliation at their discovery of her inexperience, and she shut her eyes tight, clenched teeth harder on his pant fabric until the bulbs of her jaw muscles ached in her cheeks.

Grace said, “Almost fully intact.” A flat statement, one without emotion, yet she could picture in her mind the two of them sharing a look, probably feeling bad for her; bad that they’d engaged in this powerful play with a girl and not a woman, and also sharing sympathy for her, cocking her head, mouthing Poor thing. Or worse, stifling snickers . . .

With her teeth still clenched on fabric, her lips parted and she whimpered a blubbery, “S-sorry . . .”

They’d probably thought she’d be a more experienced participant.

That throb remained, the demanding dull toothache low in her belly, that interior yearning that begged to be dismissed . . .

Ass and thighs quivering, girl muscles undulating against the incredible feel of Baron’s finger or fingers inside her, she tightened her stomach again, arched her back, got the foreign intrusion sliding against her insides again. She was rewarded with renewed pumping, Baron withdrawing his finger to her entrance then plunging shallow again. He got her breath hitching, and his pace brought bewildering pleasure. Baron’s finger strokes hurtled her forward at a freight train pace, an out-of-control cart on swooping tracks,

hurtling recklessly to a thrilling destination. Her stomach seized hard like an iron cable until it cramped. As Baron's fingers plunged in an out, throbbing pleasure, Grace's fingers—she was sure it was Grace—touched at her too, mushing and squeezing on that humming pleasure bulb, that swollen knob of sex in her nest of sopping folds. The stomach knot tightened until it hummed inside her, sizzling like a live wire—it snapped finally and she cried out a long ululating sound of exploding female pleasure she was at once ashamed and proud to deliver to the world.

With the high-tension cable snapped a wild pleasure flooded through her; the knot fully gave, and now loosened she rose on an otherworldly swell like the crown of her strawberry head may touch the high Victorian ceiling. The cries still came, her sounds of uttered pleasure flooding her cottony ears as the tidal swell raised her high enough she hurtled the other side, like breaching to a different place. All the tension, the worry, the shame, fear, regret . . . none of it mattered. All she knew was dynamic bliss that filled her with white light, a bright foggy brume of pure pleasure nullity where nothing mattered but the pinpoint of her sex, like a hole punched in a black board and held to the sun.

Only, it didn't diminish.

The pillow of pleasure kept rising, Baron's fingers still plunged, Grace still squeezed on her clitoris, and now she screamed for them to stop, begged for release from the pleasure she'd pleaded to be delivered only seconds ago.

It rolled and rolled, and she tumbled with it, pulled underwater, dragged to dark abyssal depths where she couldn't breathe, an undercurrent spinning then rising her to the stormy air where she gasped ragged to fill her lungs . . .

.

She bit and gnashed, filled her fangs with Baron's flesh to stop herself from crying out Wind Haven . . .

15

matching set

A HEAVING, SOBBING MESS IN THIS POWERFUL MAN'S LAP, THAT'S ALL she was now. Baron had done something to her she couldn't comprehend. It was an orgasm; she knew it by name, but hadn't experienced it before. Or had, she'd thought, but now it was clear the other times were close, but not complete. Grace stroked the backs of her thighs, Baron circled his hand over her lower back where her shirt doubled up. But just the weight of his hand on her delivered aftershocks that had her jittering, her stomach fluttering. His hand ran in a clockwise circle, and each sweep from 12 to 4 jumped her knees, and she grunted as residual pleasure zipped through her.

She pushed away from him and he let her go, Grace too, moving her hands away and giving Angel berth to move. Face hidden away, she braced hands on Baron, over the leg she'd bitten, and rose, putting a bare foot down on the rug. Only, when she stood, her strong legs betrayed her, going to jelly, knees unlocking. A sidestep didn't save her, her glutes fluttering but weak, all the strength she thought she had softening on her.

Both Grace and Baron jolted forward to stop her from falling or collapsing, Grace taking an arm, Baron the other arm, his large hand resting on her waist so she could lean against it. She was knock-kneed. The floor was where she wanted to be right now, at their feet where her humiliated face

was easier to hide. Her legs folded underneath her and they lowered her to the floor. She buried her face in the couch seat, hiding in her mane of hair.

When Baron spoke, his voice was calm, his tone satisfied. “I think we saw success tonight.”

If not for the plainness of his delivery—verging on solemn—she swore those were the kinds of words meant to taunt.

“I have to go,” she said, wishing she was home—even wishing she was in the dorm alone, letting India and the others go out without her, staying by herself, studying and being a good girl like she wanted to be. Still hidden in her hair, she sat upright, turned away from them.

“You can’t go,” Grace said, touching her shoulder.

“I want to go home,” she told them, her voice verging on tears.

Baron said, “You may go, pet, but sit with us first . . .”

“No,” she said, pulling herself to stand before them. Grace took her by the arm again, but this time guided her forward, and in her unsteady state it was so easy for her to fall between them, curling up against Grace and putting her hands over her face. Knees together, she curved on the couch seat, her rump turned out toward Baron. He lowered her shirt, tracing the scalloped hem where it ran over her haunch. His touch got her heart and tummy fluttering again.

Grace said, “It’s emotional, pet, I understand, sit and breathe with me, would you?”

She stayed against Grace, face covered, breathing into her own hands, enjoying the woman’s care, even the feel of her leather and her lean body. Baron remained quiet, but she could hear what sounded like him removing tissues from the side table—she imagined for cleaning off the mess she’d

made of his hand and fingers with her overflowing insides. The urge to make woeful sounds of regret rose, but she swallowed them. It would only make this more humiliating.

After a few minutes, she felt her composure may be reclaimed, and she sat up, wiping wet from her eyes, sniffing, shaking her head. “Sorry, I . . . I don’t know what to say . . .”

Grace sat up and embraced her, long arms folding around her body. She recoiled though, tried to stand again, this time making it upright without listing to one side. All down the insides of her thighs she could see the wet Baron’s ministrations produced. There was a rivulet that ran all the way to the inside of her right knee. In the gap of her parted shirt she could see her unshaved triangle beaded with her dew. Flames licked at her cheeks again, and her heart raced. “I . . . I can’t, uh, I . . .”

Grace stood, put hands on her. Their eyes met and Grace smiled. Her eyes did that dashed line thing Angel liked, but there was disquiet there too. *What had they done?*

“Come with me, Angel, please, I’ll take care of you . . .”

But she was unable to walk correctly, her gait unseemly and unsteady. Grace stepped off the rug, not headed to the door to the hall but to the door set catty corner. At her feet, Angel could see her removed panties in a tight-wound figure-eight tangle, the crotch of them darkened by her anticipation of what Baron may do to her. Grace returned, held both her hands and walked backward, leading her to the door.

Legs shaky, ass muscles quivering like she’d run a long distance, she stepped like a toddler, being led by her beautiful college professor. At the door, Grace paused, made sure Angel wouldn’t fall over, opened the door

and pushed it to swing wide. With her hand on the small of Angel's back, she guided her into the room beyond.

It was a bedroom. A four-post bed with satin canopy centered on the far wall, straddled by two nightstands; on her left there were two tall dressers, in the corner a standing mirror. On her right-hand side another door, a potted fern in a brass clawfoot stand, and a small bench where one would sit to don shoes. Under the bench she could see the backs of two pairs of women's heels, and a pair of men's dress shoes in black patent leather. The decoration of the room was the same as the rest of the mansion: Dark and Victorian, with deep colors, floral patterns, polished wood, Oriental rugs, and brass trim. And the room reminded her of staying in hotels; Grace and Baron not living here, merely staying over for the night, guests of honor maybe in this party of domination; a suit hung near the mirror on a wooden hanger, enclosed in a zippered cloth bag, and three Louis Vuitton suitcases lined along the wall where the other door led to yet another room in this suite.

"You're sleeping here?" The question was asked in a conversational tone, like she wanted to plaster over the reality—Grace's masterful husband had delivered her first real orgasm, her first profound sexual experience, and the endeavor had left her shaken and depleted.

Grace ignored the question, the answer obvious, guided her to the wall so she could lean. Grace closed the door, and as the gap narrowed, Angel could see Baron still on the sofa, attention turned down, the dumb virgin he made come already forgotten; he swiped a fresh tissue on his left thigh. Her excitement had messed the man's pants. The door closed with a quiet click, just her and her professor now.

"I'm sorry, Grace," she whispered, her back slinking down the wall like she would sit on their bedroom floor. New shame washed over her in hot sheets,

and she'd enjoy sitting cross-legged alone for a bit to cry into her hands . . .

"Angel," Grace cooed, "for what would you be sorry?"

"I don't know," she admitted, turning her face away. She just wished she'd been a more confident participant—one not so embarrassingly *green*.

Grace guided Angel's chin so they could look at each other. Grace didn't smile, but her eyes were warm and caring.

Those pouted red lips moved and Angel watched them shape the question: "You're a virgin?"

She tried to look away again, but Grace held her chin between thumb and first knuckle. She forced herself to look into the woman's dark eyes. They weren't black up close like this; dark chestnut with fine slivers of golden caramel. Angel moaned, looked down at the red lips and nodded. Grace guided her eyes to rise by tilting her chin and lowering her own face.

"And that was your first orgasm?"

"Kind of," she whispered and nodded lightly again.

Grace's eyes flashed, and her mouth worked around; her breath came heavier through her nostrils. The hand that held her chin released it, caressed her jaw, snaked under her hair to hold the back of her neck. "You may be the most precious thing I've ever encountered."

And then Grace's eyes closed to black lines, peaceful down-turned lash bows; those red lips parted. Angel reeled, knowing what was coming, head tilting back and her own lips parting. Grace's mouth closed over hers in a kiss. The woman's lips were cool and pillowy; the softness was astounding, and the act of kissing this mature and beautiful woman was light years away from kissing high school boys. Grace's mouth was supple and caring, her kiss gentle and nurturing. Not hungry with need like a boy's, but tender and

delivering care. At first Angel gave her only stiffness, but soon she was melting under her professor. Both of them breathed heavy, breath coming in pants through their nostrils. Angel's hands came up, timid and tentative, and rested on the woman's slim leather hips. Grace caressed her neck, her thumb stroked behind her ear.

Those dark feelings inside her flickered alive again, and her hands slipped higher up her professor's body.

Grace's other hand came to her leather tunic, unbuckled two straps. Her tongue slithered into Angel's mouth and she accepted it, teasing it with her own tongue. Grace's tongue was a supple and smooth wet thing, and again so unlike a boy's.

She started to tremble again, legs shaking, knees coming together. Her core heated, and she felt new slickness arising.

The front of Grace's tunic hung open in a narrow gap, and while they still kissed, she guided Angel's hand inside her outfit. Her professor wore nothing underneath, and she felt the woman's warm, lean body. Her hand curved her ribcage, admired the grace, admired the supple feel. Her hand rose higher, and Grace didn't stop her. Her palm went over the woman's bare breast, and she gasped into her professor's mouth at the hard aroused nub of the woman's nipple. Grace's breast was a small teacup rise of soft woman-flesh, and she guessed not too much unlike her own. But she couldn't imagine Grace fretting over the size of her breasts or allowing her boyfriend to make her feel inferior. Grace was strong and confident, and Angel's heart went heavy with envy for this powerful woman.

The kiss ended. Their mouths parted with a soft wet sound, and Grace had left her heaving for breath again. Warm dampness had sealed her thighs together in a sticky seam.

Grace said, “You’re welcome to stay the night.”

Angel’s eyes widened, and a spike of adrenalin shook her out of the honey-coated dreamland where the woman’s kiss had sent her. Images flashed at her of three naked people intertwined in a bed, and the stupid college virgin was clumsy and oafish, and the other two members of the sexual troika grew exasperated by her ineptitude . . .

“I think I just want to go home,” she said as Grace stepped back, Angel’s hand slipping out of the warm glove of the woman’s leather suit. Her fingers intertwined because she didn’t know what to do with her hands again.

Grace studied her for a few beats, then that smile flashed and her eyes did the happy cartoon thing, and a weird smirk tugged at Angel’s mouth. She looked down at the floor.

Grace unhooked the clasp of her cloak, then slung it to lay on the made bed. “Wait there,” she said, moved to a dresser and opened the second drawer from the top. She returned with a wadded bunch of fabric in one hand and pushed it into Angel’s.

“You’ll need to freshen before we send you home.”

Angel nodded, her thumb flicking over the soft satiny feel of what had been passed to her; they were undergarments, briefs and a bra. Angel gave Grace a questioning look.

Grace smiled again. “I don’t think you want to put on the ones you wore into our suite.”

The obvious was left unsaid, and she appreciated the woman’s manners. No, the panties left in a bunch on the parlor floor would be a cold damp mess to put back on.

Grace said, “There’s a bathroom beyond this door,” flicking her eyes past Angel’s shoulder, “have a hot shower, or bath, if you like, and I’ll arrange a way home for you.”

Angel nodded, the relationship between them fading in dominance and sexuality, and becoming supportive. “Okay,” she whispered, “Thank you,” eyes still down watching her thumb move over the underwear her professor had offered. “I think . . . I just could use the bottoms . . .”

Grace said, “They come as a set, we shouldn’t split them up.” Her smile flashed again, and she gestured to the bathroom door . . .

16

red stripes 2

GRACE SHOWED HER THE ROOM WHERE SHE COULD SCRUB AWAY HER shame. It was a small but luxurious space with gold gleaming fixtures and oyster shell porcelain; a pedestal sink with vanity mirror stood next to a two-tiered stand in mahogany. The tub was a clawfoot, a shower rod ran a half moon above, brass clips holding a velvet paisley shower curtain. Angel placed the underthings on the table that served as a countertop.

Grace still stood in the doorway. Angel said, “Did I . . . please him?”

Grace’s hand swept Angel’s upper back, squeezed her shoulder. “You want to please him?”

“Isn’t that the transaction?”

Grace huffed a quiet laugh. “You definitely pleased him, Angel.”

Her eyes tracked the mirror, seeking Grace. Their gaze met in the reflection. “Was there more he expected?”

Grace said, “Baron’s a dominant of the highest order. If there were more he wanted, he would have conjured it from you.”

“I feel like I disappointed him.”

“That’s Baron’s charm.”

Now she gave a gentle laugh too. “Making girls feel . . . unworthy?”

“He knows how to draw you nearer.”

She shivered, the act visible—Grace touched a palm between her shoulder blades. Angel said, “That’s something I could never do again.”

“Now *that* would disappoint him.”

The hand circled her back, and she enjoyed the feeling. Grace said, “Believe me when I tell you Baron *knows* what you want. What he showed you tonight was only a glimpse of what he could do to you.”

All he did was finger her. *But it was a lot more than that, wasn’t it?* Something simmered below the surface. Baron turned up the heat. Other boys had fingered her before. Not one of them came close to what Baron had done. Her legs still wobbled from the pleasure that had been ripped from her.

Now Grace said, “Baron’s sought after for what he brings. And he’s selective. There are subs that would give anything for his strong hand.”

Did that make her special? Or was Baron doing a favor for his wife? Was it Grace’s whim to offer up a fun taste for a curious student of hers?

That wasn’t a *taste* she’d been given.

How much could she endure? What Baron’d done was overwhelming, and the idea she could ever find herself tied to a table and flogged was impossible.

The truth was *none* of it was her. She was a good girl.

A nagging tug between her hips complained—but what she saw and did tonight was something *other* people did, not something for young student-athletes trying to make grades, fulfill scholarships, and make proud her parents.

“I need to get cleaned up,” she said.

Grace patted her back, squeezed her shoulder, moved to the tub and showed Angel how to run the hot water. Angel told her she’d prefer a shower, she really should get going, and Grace flicked a lever, getting the spray hissing from a gold shower-head as broad as a dessert plate. Angel thanked her, Grace told her she’d collect Angel’s clothes, then left her alone in the bathroom.

Alone now with the water hissing in the shower, she regarded the girl she saw in the mirror. The urge to look away was strong, but she kept the gaze. The girl in the mirror was a mess. Eyes bleary, cheeks reddened from the humiliation she’d received over Baron’s knee. Grace’s lipstick marked her own lips, pale and faded, but under the mirror’s light she could see ragged prints where her professor had kissed her. She backhanded her mouth, but it made little difference. She assessed now her features. Grace and Baron had called her beautiful. Her features weren’t noteworthy. Her lips weren’t plump pillows like Grace’s, her eyes not narrow and sexy like India’s. They were pretty eyes, but in the symmetry of her face as a complete canvas all she saw was a plain girl. Her nose was straight and fine, her cheeks high, her chin narrow. But she was unremarkable; as noteworthy as a stop sign; one regular face among millions.

Tired of what she saw in the mirror, she removed her shirt and bra, stepped under the shower’s spray . . .

IT TOOK a lot of soap before the swipe of her hands between her legs lost their slipperiness and felt scrubbed clean.

Hair tied up in a loose bun on top of her head, she stepped out of the shower now and onto the plush bathmat. Her skin blazed red from the hot water. She'd scorched herself raw, but the heat soothed some tension that'd locked across her shoulders and back. Plush towels curved a gold rack, and she plucked two free, dried herself in warm comfort.

The undergarments lay on the countertop table by the bathroom sink, and she sorted them now, separating bra from briefs, flattening them on the rose-veined marble counter. Arranged on a clean white towel at sink-side were nail clippers, and other manicure utensils, including a small pair of scissors that Angel used to shear the string that held the tags in place. She checked the price before tossing them in the small trash between vanity and toilet, then absently did the math in her head as she examined the fineness of the undergarments Grace Chen liked for herself. The two items combined—a porch bra and panties—came to £200. Two hundred Sterling would be what?—almost three hundred dollars . . .? Not quite, but still . . . Who paid that much for underthings, fine as they were, all the way from England? Well, Grace Chen. She also gave them away freely. The bottoms were sheer except for a front and crotch panel in lavender satin that would cover her intimate parts. The sheerness of the fabric was embroidered with elaborately designed, hand drawn roses in indigo; the waistband was a scalloped trim. The tulle felt as soft as silk as she ran her fingertips against the underside. The bra matched; satin in pale lavender, blue stitched roses, and wide flat straps in indigo that had to be silk. She donned them now, putting legs through the panties and marveling at the soft feel of the fabric, slipping her breasts into the cups of the bra, also wonderfully comfortable. Contentment came from knowing she and Grace wore the same size.

She regarded herself in the mirror, turning side to side, rotating and checking out the back, the way the panties curved the roundness of her rump, the way the hand drawn roses scrawled over her—

“Oh no,” she gasped, startled.

Clear hand prints, large ones, blazed her pale flesh, rising red and sore, peeking out from behind the expensive panties, and showing high on the backs of her thighs. “Shit,” she hissed, rearing right around to get a good look at her ass in the mirror, handling her own butt now, trying to figure out if those hand marks would show below her running shorts. She had practice tomorrow . . .

She sighed heavily, ran a hand over her brow like she had a fever. Then laughed. She would wear tights. It was cold anyway.

ANGEL EMERGED FROM THE BATHROOM, and Grace watched the timid thing. Her hair was bundled atop her head, the young girl not wanting the labor of drying it when all she thought she wanted was to be back at her dorm. A shoulder, her face, a knee—that was all Angel presented them. Her clothing had been folded and left for her on the bed, and if she wanted to don them, she would cross the room and let them admire her. Grace gestured to the items arranged on the bed, the black clothing Angel had worn out this evening as though she and her friends were burglars.

When Angel stayed safe behind the door, Grace said, “Come out and let us see you.”

Angel did one of those tense expressions she often gave, her pretty features twisted with anxiety. “Come out, Angel,” she said again, “you’re safe with us.”

The girl disappeared from the doorway and Grace swore she was making faces where they couldn't see her—then the door moved open again, and she stepped out into the bedroom wearing the lavender set of undergarments she'd bought last month in London and had never got to wearing. The girl was beautiful in them. But Angel stood knees together, toes turned in, one arm down, the other crossed over her breasts, hand clutching the opposite shoulder.

"They fit you well," Grace said.

"Yeah," Angel said. "Yes."

Angel's eyes moved aside, regarding Baron who'd come to the bedroom and had removed his cloak and suit, changed into his robe. Baron stood at the foot of their bed watching the pretty young thing with a blank expression. When Baron's eyes met hers, Angel looked at the floor. Angel said, "Thank you for lending them."

"They're yours to keep, dear," she said. Angel's eyes widened, but she didn't object. It was progress. "Would you show me them?"

Angel chewed her lower lip—a habit they would break—and let her arms hang, head aside. She was still tense, her posture rigid. It was crazy because the girl had a fine and shapely figure, but whatever had cinched up her sexuality had bound it well. She wasn't comfortable in her own skin. If she were, she would be a tiger.

Grace said, "Turn around."

Angel did, staying in place, shuffling a circle on the wool rug. As her backside was exposed, the girl tried to cover her bottom with her hands. Grace looked to Baron and gave him a sympathetic smile. The girl was incredible.

“Move your hands, please,” Baron said, the sound of his deep voice making Angel flinch.

Angel paused a moment, but slowly her hands came away and showed them her perfect ass laced with the marks of her husband’s hand. Grace chuckled and strolled the distance between them.

Angel had run a hot shower; Grace could feel the damp heat still radiating from her bare skin, and her shoulders were reddened by the water’s hot sting. Grace touched the girl’s waist, watched her jump and bristle, saw goose bumps rise on her upper arms. Her hands went down to cup the girl’s round and taut ass; an abundant one, but healthy and firm and athletic. She whispered, “You wear Baron’s marks so well.”

Angel whispered, “Thank you,” making Grace smile. Angel added: “Mistress.”

Grace stroked the small of the girl’s back. Their Angel was too much to hope for. An absolute perfect thing standing in their bedroom. She whispered, “I don’t think we’re done. What do you think?”

Angel turned her head aside; Grace watched her profile as she chewed now her lower lip. Angel said, “I should go home. Please . . .”

Grace smiled, stroked her shoulder, ran a fingertip under the wide silk strap of the bra she’d given her student. “Next week, Angel, there’s a gala at the MFA in Boston—”

“What’s that?”

“The Museum of Fine Arts. An opening for a new exhibition, contemporary masters, and a fundraiser for Mass General. I’m flying out to meet Baron at our place on the coast. We’d like you to be our guest for the weekend . . .”

17

exposure

ACROSS THE ROOM, AT THE FOOT OF THE BED, BARON STOOD WATCHING her while his wife tickled her back. “Go away with you?”

Baron said, “Yes. Our guest for the weekend at the Rhode Island house.” His manner was direct, but she could detect in his voice an eagerness for her to join them. But what would that entail? More than just bent over a knee, more than spanked and fingered, of that she was sure.

“I don’t know . . .”

Baron made no more encouragement and stayed calmly watching her. The man had disrobed. Gone was the suit, the mysterious cloak and cowl, the gauntlets . . . when she’d first discovered him, he’d been a fearsome figure all in black and whipping a screaming, begging girl. In the last hour she’d seen his mask removed, discovered the gorgeous face behind it, saw the gauntlets come off, saw the large and handsome hands. Now the suit was gone, and she witnessed him in his intimate setting, ready for bed, wearing only a luxurious deep colored robe in satin or silk, the shimmering fabric printed in small geometric shapes.

But he wasn’t vulnerable. Even reduced to almost nakedness the man still exuded tremendous power. He had a large and intimidating frame; a blue

collar frame. A big man like the tough men she knew at home, only Baron's exterior glistened with the polished pampering of wealth. His eyes shone with sharp intelligence, and deep knowing, but his body was hard and capable. She could see it evidenced in the glimpses of his bare chest the robe provided between the wide black lapels.

Baron was finished waiting for a response from her and now sat on the bed as though she were dismissed. But the act of sitting showed one vulnerability.

And it was the damage she'd done to him.

The robe's hem rose and slipped up his knee exposing the side of Baron's thigh. Even from across the room she could see the bruise her bite had left him. When he'd drawn out that tremendous orgasm, the force with which it ripped from her had her gnashing teeth clamped on his flesh.

She covered her gasping mouth as bewildering fright chilled her. *She'd* done that to him; and though Baron was the one who'd left *his* masculine mark over her ass and thighs, she regretted harming him. "Oh no," she whispered behind her hand. Grace's tickling stilled.

"What is it?"

"Did I do that to him?"

Before Grace could answer, Angel was crossing the room, her legs making the decision for her, her mind challenged by *more* than regret now. A shame for sure, embarrassment, but also a worry. If she'd harmed Baron, would he want to harm her in return? Or worse, would her carelessness dismiss her from future engagements over his knee—*wait a second, why would you ever consider a second round over the man's knee?* Hadn't the decision been made to stay innocent? Was she already looking to betray her responsible decision?

She went to her knees at his feet, looking up and showing him an apologetic face. Both hands went to either side of his knee. “I’m so sorry,” she said.

Baron showed no anger. He sat on the end of the bed, knees apart, looking down on her, his face framed in her vision by the rising posts at the foot of the bed, and the dark of the canopy.

He said, “We all wear our marks.”

A sudden and strange—almost sickly—urge took hold of her, and she kissed his knee. Grace came to join them, climbing up to lounge next to Baron on the end of the bed, embracing her husband’s arm.

Angel thumbed away the robe’s hem to look at how she’d injured the man. The mark was a mottled blotch of purple, a vague red dashed line scribing the middle—her bite pattern, only her top row making the wound. Now she kissed near her mark.

Under her hands and lips, Baron’s skin was warm, and life pulsed below the surface. She’d never kissed a man intimately anywhere on his body—not like this. Brian had forced her to put his penis in her mouth, but that wasn’t the same as pressing your lips to someone and feeling them against that enormously sensitive sensory receptor. Her lips gauged so much of him.

Baron’s hand caressed her now, and she willingly put her cheek in the cup of his huge palm and looked up to him. A smile slowly pushed back his cheeks, and she saw he dimpled. Baron was a man, but that smile showed the youthful boyish side of him. Seeing it brought her own smile. Baron smoothed the point of her chin with the cushion of his thumb.

He said, “You’re forgiven, pet.”

It was so demeaning to be referred to as property like that, affectionate as it was. Yet, his words brought her warm comfort. She kissed the muscular

hump of his hand's heel, still looking up. Grace watched as well, smiling, caressing Baron's arm. But now a hand dropped lower, into her husband's lap. Angel watched Grace undo the knot of Baron's tassel belt, then draw the ends away.

It was merely an invitation to look if she was curious; Grace's way of giving Angel permission. Because Grace didn't open Baron's robe. Her hand returned to embrace Baron's arm, hugging herself to her husband and smiling, eyes going narrow.

It took a long while, heart thundering the whole time, but at last Angel rose to her knees between Baron's open legs. She sucked on her bottom lip, ran her fingertips along the satiny hem of Baron's robe where it coursed over his thigh. She was supposed to get out of here.

But she wanted to see him. Wanted all the leather, the cloak . . . *all* the costuming removed. She wanted to see what the man looked like bare. Breath held now, she peeled away one side of the robe, her other hand crossing over, peeling away the other side.

Baron Gravesande was a man, not a boy. His chest was a curved slab, his midsection hard and chiseled; the way he sat folded multiple lines in his thin skin where it crossed at his navel. But between his legs was proof of his bona fide manhood. Not like what she'd ever known before, the thing hanging between Baron's legs was an impossibly large, heavy, *elephantine* thing. She hitched breath further into her lungs, truly shocked. It dangled over the edge of the bed, curled over a packed pink scrotum and resting on the shiny black underside of his robe.

Grace ran her feminine hand over Baron's stomach, circling on him, her pinky finger raking through the patch of pubic hair where her husband's monstrous endowment emerged from his body.

Grace whispered, “Stay with us . . .”

BARON ACHED FOR HER, but could see in her eyes tonight was not the night—the girl needed much more preparation. His manhood didn’t heed the restraint his mind forged; it filled with excited blood, lengthening and thickening, and the more Angel marveled—her eyes glued to his genitals—the more *rushed* the feeling coursing through his cock. It began to lift. Then fell to one side and rested on his thigh. Angel’s eyes went wider, and she moved away.

Grace said to the girl, “Why don’t you stay with us—would you like to watch us make love?” It was a wonderful course of action. Grace’s hand slipped lower, and she gripped him, pleased him. “What do you think?” she asked Angel. He knew it wasn’t to be.

“I gotta go,” the girl said blankly, eyes between his legs, but beginning to rise, going on her heels, bracing his knees to stand. She was a flawless thing in Grace’s fine lingerie. Her breasts sat perked in the cups of the bra, and her tummy was a taut stretch of female flesh he couldn’t wait to feel against his palms. And when he thought of those marks he’d left her with he surged harder between his legs, his erection rising higher. It frightened Angel, so he covered it over with the flaps of his robe.

Grace chuckled and slipped off the bed, went to Angel to support her. The girl’s eyes had gone wet and shiny, her cheeks showed a new blossom of blush. It spread now, too, over her collar.

The sight of his beautiful wife embracing her young student drove him wilder, and he closed his legs on his turgid manhood. Angel shook her head, wiped at a cheek, and Grace laughed, rubbed the girl’s arm. His wife smiled

and said to him, “The poor girl doesn’t want to ruin another set of briefs tonight.”

Angel did a cute smirk that only went to one side, then she shied away.

He said, “Escort her to the car. Make sure Mr. Jones gets her wherever she’s going safe and sound . . .”

18

on ivory leather

THEY'D WATCHED HER DON THE CLOTHES IN WHICH SHE'D ARRIVED, and now she was mind-numb and being led on her professor's slender arm down a narrow back hallway that bypassed the party and its wild rooms of erotic play. When she told Grace she'd come without a coat, Grace chided her, presented her with one of her own. Angel'd refused, but Grace insisted. She was cloaked in a knee-length black wool overcoat with silk interior and notched lapels and two rows of large buttons down the front. It tied at the waist, the wool unbelievably feather soft. Grace's heavenly smell clung to its fibers.

They emerged in an empty shut-down commercial kitchen, the lights off except for low under-counter lights that put a dull gleam on all the square stainless surfaces. Grace stopped with her at a heavy metal door with a wide push-bar and held her shoulders. "You were wonderful tonight."

Angel nodded, looked down, said, "Thank you, I guess . . . It was all so . . ."

"It will take time for you to straighten it all in your mind. There's no rush." Grace lowered her face, angled her eyes so they looked into one another. "Okay?"

"Okay," she said, nodding again.

Grace said, “I want you to think about next weekend. It would be our pleasure to have you stay with us. I guarantee you will have an incredible time. Not just at the gala . . .”

“I’ll have to think about it.”

Grace cupped her cheeks, stroked underneath her eye with a thumb. “Think about it,” she said.

Grace led the way through the metal door. It opened onto a small brick courtyard rimmed with gardens bundled in burlap to protect them from the approaching winter. Grace took her hand and led her across the bricks, under a wooden trellis and onto a flat macadam court. They were behind the mansion, music bumping from somewhere within, but this angle on the home quiet and unattended. There were two cars parked noses away from her near a two-story barn with a red-brick first floor, large black carriage house doors set with glass, four of them, the top floor in Tudor style with stucco and dark beams. At one time a couple hundred years ago this would have been built to house the family’s horse-drawn coaches and their tack. At the far left end of the carriage house there was a smaller human-size door, and outside it, standing on the stoop under a massive two-foot tall metal lantern, a man in a suit stood waiting for them.

“Mr. Jones,” Grace called out through the cold brittle night.

The man stepped forward out of the cone of lantern light, saying, “Yes, Madame?”

They met outside the coach house, Grace introducing her saying, “This is Miss Parker. She’ll need a ride back to Morrison. What dorm, Angel?”

“Roth.”

“Rothschild Hall,” she said to the middle-aged man named Mr. Jones. “You know your way.”

“I do indeed. Come with me, if you please, Miss Parker, let me help you to the vehicle.”

Grace held her a moment longer, Mr. Jones continuing on to the carriage house door. Grace said to her, “Give me your phone.”

Angel took it from her pocket and passed it to her professor.

“Open it.”

She did, and then Grace opened Angel’s contacts and entered her information, then sent herself a message. Grace’s phone chimed from somewhere inside her outfit. She passed the phone back.

“I’ll be in touch,” she said, holding Angel’s neck for a second then letting her go. She smiled, said, “Promise me you’ll think about coming to Boston,” and didn’t wait for an answer, pivoting, cape swirling, then striding to return to the mansion, heels clapping on the hard pack.

Angel let go a long disbelieving exhale, turned to the carriage house and walked to Mr. Jones who stood holding the door for her.

WHEN GRACE RETURNED to their suite Baron was coming out of the bathroom, obviously in a playful mood. Both of them showed expressions bordering glee. He flashed open wider his robe and showed he hadn’t lost his arousal while she’d walked Angel to the carriage house. Her husband was fully hard, his tremendous cock wagging and bouncing out in front of him as he came to her.

They embraced, and she pushed with her stomach his arousal, flattening it between them. It had been a powerful evening, and the art of domination she and her husband had performed tonight roused both of them to heights they'd anticipated all week. And that was *before* her young student had auditioned as a cast member in their erotic productions. What they would do now in their bed together would be something their pretty Angel should have witnessed.

Baron held her in a powerful and eager grip, his large hands crushing her arms. He moaned when he kissed her; she gave him her tongue and mimicked his leonine grumble.

Their kiss parted. His eyes flashed over hers. They both smiled. He studied her face, and she opened it to him as he caressed her now, spread his hand over her collar and gripped her neck.

He sighed, looking so satisfied with her, both of them practically purring with the passion they held for each other. He said, "What did you find, Grace?"

Her cheek went to his strong chest. She said, "*She* found *us*."

THE TRIP HOME with Mr. Jones was a journey in buttery luxury though her ass and the backs of her thighs buzzed. She sat in the backseat of a black Range Rover as she'd been instructed by her professor's driver, or whatever he was. When she'd complained about sitting in the back, Mr. Jones had told her there would be trouble for him if she rode up front, so if she was as considerate as she looked she'd climb in the back and enjoy the ride.

She'd queried him at first as they made their way off the mansion's grounds and onto the country road back into town, but he was deflective,

misdirecting her questions with vague non-answers. She did glean that he was the attendant of both Mr. Gravesande and Mrs. Chen, and that the Range Rover was Grace's personal vehicle, at least when she was in Vermont. But any more questions sent his way became converted to questions asked of her, and she got the point: Stop asking questions.

Only problem was, when she was left alone the quiet peace invited her own voice and thoughts of what had transpired on a simple night out with college friends. At the night's onset she'd been worried about her social awkwardness when foisted into a happy, party-hungry conclave of normal people her own age. Where the evening had ended up could never have been predicted. A certain happy satisfaction slithered through her. She'd made it through a night out. She'd gone out with friends. She could tell her mother that. That brought the happiness's contrary: Shame. What she'd done couldn't be iterated to anyone. Not her mother, God, no, and not even her friends.

She texted India.

Angel: back at dorm

Angel: hungry so went for milkshake

There was a diner on the main street, very close to campus, and it made milkshakes like it was still the 1950s. They were served in tall steel containers, frosted from the ice cream, and you could pour them into a fluted glass yourself. Everyone knew she loved them, so if someone saw she wasn't in her dorm room, they wouldn't panic.

Soon she and Mr. Jones were out of the countryside and slipping along the quiet nighttime of Morrison's downtown. It was just after midnight. Clutches of boisterous students from Morrison ambled the street or stood in groups sending up clouds of vape smoke. The main street had two bars, and

both of their entrances were buffeted by more kids from Morrison. They passed the diner. It was packed. She hid her face and watched through the windows while they passed—though the Range Rover’s windows were so heavily tinted no one could see who was within. Who would look for her, anyway? And in the off chance they were looking, would they ever consider *she* could be a passenger in the British luxury truck? There was no sign of familiar faces in the diner anyway, and now Mr. Jones had them driving under the bare branch canopy of Morrison’s main entrance, turning right at the McNeil building and heading toward Rothschild.

She asked Mr. Jones: “Would you drop me off here?” They were coming around the corner, the lit up front entrance of her ancient dorm hall in front of them where more students hung around.

“Right to the door, Miss,” he said.

“What’ll they think seeing me get out of this truck?” She leaned between the two front seats wrapped in soft ivory leather and watched out the window at the students standing outside Roth.

Mr. Jones said, “Who cares?”

From his mirthful eyes watching her in the rearview she knew he kidded. She said, “Please?”

“No, ma’am, if I don’t see you to the door and something happens to you between here and there do you know what becomes of me?”

“You can pull over here and watch me walk to the door . . .”

The Rover slowed; Mr. Jones sighed. “Fair enough.”

Sliding from the height of the truck to set her feet on the sidewalk proved painful. Her bottom slid over the stiff lip of the leather bench and her

cheeks complained. Once down she turned and thanked Mr. Jones for the ride.

“My pleasure, Miss Parker. You take care.”

She closed the door of the truck and walked under the streetlight, head down, passing near the group of students. What *would* they think seeing her getting out of that vehicle? The truth was awful, but would it be decipherable to prying eyes? Right now, in her purse, the bundled and dampened underwear she'd worn when she left this evening were wadded up and hidden. She wore her professor's fancy set of expensive bra and panties. Her professor's husband had spanked her and then fingered her until she had her first orgasm. Did she wear that shame on her face? Did she show it in her walk? This might be the most absurd walk of shame the brick face of Rothschild ever witnessed. And if the students watching her pass suspected her indiscretion, all they would have to do is toss her onto the grass and peel down her tights. Her ass showed the marks of Baron's powerful discipline. Her stride quickened, and she trotted up the steps, moving fast, huddled in Grace's heavenly scented coat, heart rate kicked up higher.

She didn't stop till she had hands on the doors, looking back now to see the kids had no interest in her at all, laughing and vaping. She smirked, huffed, waved to the Range Rover, then ran up to her dorm room.

INDIA WASN'T BACK from wherever she and Abby had gone after the party at the mansion, and Angel got ready for bed in peace. Grace's fine underthings were removed, carefully folded and hidden in the dresser underneath her sweatshirts. The coat was hung on the rack at the foot of her bed. Loose Hager Hill Hawks sweatpants without underwear were chosen

for the comfort of her still stinging bottom, and a too-large frayed flannel shirt of her father's. In bed she lay and looked at the ceiling and listened to the steady beat of her heart, elevated, but not rapid.

What the hell had she done tonight?

19

long time coming

SLEEP WAS ELUSIVE. SHE WAS IN AND OUT, FITFUL, DOZING OFF THEN kicking awake. India hadn't returned.

Around two she began to wonder if she should worry. By 2:10 she'd concocted a scenario that got her believing India could be in trouble. From Grace and Baron's salon, she'd texted India and given her roommate a story at their behest, telling India she was already on the way home in an Uber. And here she was thinking she'd fooled India. But what if India had been fooling her? What if it wasn't even India she'd been texting? Maybe India and Abby were imprisoned in Mr. Fairbanks's chamber, him showing them his project—his big, long, *hard* project . . .

Now sleep was impossible.

She got up, tired of staring at Grace's black coat, knowing she should move it, realizing now that as much as she liked to lay and see it hanging at the foot of her bed, when India came home she probably wouldn't want to answer India's questions on such a fine coat's provenance. She got up, put it in her closed closet. That's when she heard voices coming down the hall. Could be anybody, there were lots of people living in the dorm . . . And she heard India's laugh. Relieved, she jumped back into bed pretending to be asleep.

Two people came into their shared dorm room, and through squinted eyes she could see it was Kimball escorting India's return to the dorm room. They close the door behind them, the two of them lingering in their dorm room's small foyer. They talked quietly, Kimball whispering something, India chuckling and shushing him. There was quiet. Then the sands of kissing.

Angel hugged herself tighter under the covers. Footsteps then, two sets, going slow, stumbling. She chanced a look over her shoulder to see India and Kimball walking backward, India leading in Kimball's embrace. They fell on the bed together, both of them laughing, then India shushing Kimball. They whispered into each other's ears; more giggling. Then soft sounds of fabric rubbing, their bodies against each other, a gentle moan from India.

The sexual sound of her friend got Angel's stomach in a tight grip again. She squirmed, chewed the inside of her cheek and listened. More soft talking, more kissing. A clunk-clunk. Kimball taking off his shoes and letting them drop to the dorm room floor. Then whisking fabric, a softer clunk-clunk, India's shoes now. India and Kimball getting under the sheets; more giggling. Kissing sounds. It went on for a little while then the sound of a belt being undone. Zippers. Clothes slipping off. Things thrown on the floor now. More kissing. Less talking. A drawer opened. Plastic rustling. Latex sounds. Kimball putting on a condom. India gasped as Kimball entered her body. The bed squeaked. Slow at first and syncopated. Squeak. Squeak. Then heavy breathing . . .

And God, here it was coming again. All down from her sternum to her swollen ball of sex between her legs growing hard and tight. She squeezed her ass muscles, then slowly worked herself around to face India's bed. She could see their shapes undulating under the dorm room sheets. Kimball's ass going up and down. The points of India's sheet-covered knees wagging

in and out. Squeak, squeak, squeak. The crinkling sound of latex. God, her chest was blazing, her cheeks and ears too . . .

She slipped a hand down her warm stomach and then underneath her sweatpants. Her fingers found the sopping mess between her legs, and gently teased at her forward most commissure, finding the nub already hard and bursting from its sheath. Then as she listened to her roommate's most intimate pleasure—the soft sounds India made when she had sex, the thin trail of her voice in her moaning—she crushed her eyes closed. She thought of her hand inside Grace's leather suit. That warm woman feel. Thought of the hardness of Grace's nipple against her palm. Then she thought of Baron. Thought of that robe flap opened, then the other one, revealing him naked. Thought of his manhood. Though she'd averted her gaze, the image of it was frozen in her mind's eye. Big, heavy looking. Lustrous sagging skin, a beautiful male thing. That round glans shape, so large, as big as a ping pong ball, and he wasn't even aroused . . . Now she thought of it hard. What would it look like? She could picture Brian's and knew Baron's wouldn't look like that. Would his rise upright, would it curve? . . . Would it bow or angle sideways? Hang? How big would it be? She humped her hips against her wriggling fingers, wet flesh sounds hidden underneath her roommate's gasps of pleasure in the bed next to her.

Now she pictured herself like India. On her back in this very dorm room bed, that tall—oh so very tall—handsome man between her thighs. That huge thing he had between his legs was hard, huge, and was pulsing in and out of her body and Angel Parker wasn't a virgin anymore . . .

That salon sickness wormed through her again, a squirrely anfractuous thing; a belly full of sex snakes slithering in her insides, and she cried into her hand as she came at the same time India did . . .

RED THROBBING WAVES emanated from her hot molten core, laying there in secret basking pleasure in her dorm room bed with a wet hand pinched between her thighs. On her side, alone, she watched the dim shapes of Kimball and India in India's bed. Two people together doing that dirty thing, now quietly talking, small soft laughs under the covers.

Like she'd just sprinted, her breath came hard. Mouth open, chest heaving, she did her best to remain noiseless. Her temples throbbed. Pleasure worked in her heart.

Her fingers explored. Grave and Baron said she was intact. Her opening was tight, what she thought was her hymen a membrane seal, penetrable, a thin webbing. A penis had never been inside her. Fingers yes, but only a few times. *Imagine Baron putting his erection inside your body . . .* a soft airy puff of a moan escaped her lips.

Fabric sounds startled her, eyes snapping open. Kimball rose from the bed to stand near her, an arm's length away.

He stretched, his penis wagging stiffly, evidence of his success swinging heavily in the condom's reservoir tip. The nighttime light beyond their dorm room window fell on his body from the gap in their parted curtain, moonlight on his summer-home tan, fading erection nodding between his legs with his heartbeat.

Now he was looking at her, squinting through the darkness and catching her awake and eyes open, looking at his dick. She gulped, squeezed her eyes closed till they hurt, listened to him climbing back into bed with India. Heard him whisper to her roommate: "I think your roommate was watching us."

WHEN SHE WOKE to the early morning sunlight, Kimball was gone. Wintry November sunshine fell through their dorm room windows, lighting a square cross India's leg. India was awake too, laying head propped up on a pillow, knees bent, feet flat on her mattress. She was flipping through messages on her phone.

Despite the enormity of what transpired last night, waking in her dorm room bed seemed safe. Something in her had been changed, but now she was just a Morrison college girl with a Saturday and Sunday off, books to read, essays to write . . .

She said to India, "What time is it?"

India smiled looking her way saying, "Hey, you're up."

Angle squinted, raised her face to the window. "Look how sunny it is."

"Awesome, I know." India set down her phone, turned to lay on her side facing Angel. "Sorry about last night."

"About Kimball?"

"That too."

Angel said nothing, and they looked at each other, quiet, faces pleasant.

India sat up, stretching, putting her feet on the floor. She strode one step across and collapsed on Angel's bed next to her. "I'm sorry for ditching you last night. I didn't mean for that to happen, and that was super shitty."

"You didn't ditch me."

"You kinda ditched me I guess, but I feel responsible."

"Responsible for me?"

"I did," India said.

“Don’t worry,” Angel said. “I had fun.”

“Did you?”

“I did.”

They looked at each other. India smiled. “What the hell was going on at that mansion, huh?”

She laughed, and India laughed too. Angel rolled to her back, and India shifted closer, both of them now looking up at the dorm room ceiling, shoulder to shoulder.

India said, “What about the frat party? Was that okay?”

“It was all right. Hey, is Abby okay?”

“Yeah. She’s fine. She danced it off. We came back out to the couch and you weren’t there, she was pretty mad . . .”

“I’m so sorry, I—”

“Abby’s the queen of doing shit like that, she has nothing to say. We went outside, looking for you . . .”

“I just got weirded out.”

“I don’t blame you. There were at least half a dozen guys on the dance floor all in leather, with like the front of their pants cut off,” she used the blade edges of her hand to jab a V at her own pajama front crotch. “I swear to God they had their dicks out, Angel. It’s a good thing you didn’t come out dancing. They’re dancing around with their things slapping all over the place.” India covered her face and laughed, breathed into her cupped hands for a moment. “Anyway, we went into town, went to the diner. Thought you might be there, but we must’ve missed you. Abby had a milkshake, and she bounced back. We went back to the Chi house.”

Angel huffed a small laugh, crossed her arms. “So you and Kimball . . .?”

“That happened.”

“I guess it was a long time coming.”

“It was.”

“How was it?”

“It was a long time coming.”

Angel turned her face to India. “You’re glad it happened?”

“I’m not *unhappy* about it . . .”

Angel watched India’s profile as her expressionless face spread into a smile. Without looking over, India nudged her, and it was the most youthful and playful thing India had ever done. Like friends. Angel nudged back. And as the good feeling spread through her she couldn’t help herself asking the thing most prominent on her mind: “You know Professor Chen?”

India looked her way. “We have history class *together*, Angel.”

“Right, but you know anything *about* her?”

“No, like what? She writes books or something . . .”

“Do you know if she’s married?”

India showed a puzzled expression. “Why?”

She was wedged in now, and there was no backing out. “I saw her with a guy last night in town.”

“At the diner?”

“No, not there . . .” Now she faked a puzzled expression of her own. “I think it was her. Her and a really tall man walking on the street.”

India’s puzzled expression began to ease. “What does this guy look like?”

“Tall, blonde hair.”

“Smoke-show?”

“What does that mean?”

“Hotty.”

She considered a more gracious answer, but said: “Yes.”

India crooned slyly: “*All* right, Professor Chen . . .”

“So you don’t know?”

“Hold on,” she said, bounced off the bed, went to hers, grabbed her iPad off the night table and then flopped back down again. She brought the iPad to life, opened a browser and searched for: Grace Chen husband.

Angel watched over India’s shoulder as she scanned through articles and images. Angel said, “Wait, there . . .”

A photo taken at a black tie function, some party in downtown NYC, Soho. Grace Chen in a cardinal red dress, hair pulled back and looking beautiful, adorned in chunky gold jewelry. The man at her side was Baron Gravesande. Six-and-a-half feet tall, white smile, tanned, dashing, handsome head of hair . . .

“What—seriously, *that* guy?” India was impressed.

“That looks like him.”

“Holy shit, look at that guy. Baron Gravesande . . .” India sounding it out, getting the pronunciation wrong. Saying it Grave-sand rather than Grav-uh-zand-eh.

India said to Baron’s picture: “Well who are you, my handsome husband-to-be?”

“He’s already married.”

India shrugged it off, laughing, and Angel watched as India flicked through screens again, ending up on a Wikipedia page. “Nothing about him, which is weird. But it looks like he might be a part of the Gravesande family, which is also part of the Van Heusen family. And the Van Heusen family is old Dutch, Mayflower times, thirteen colonies, owned *all* of New York at one point in history type money.”

“Really?”

“Yeah,” India said, reading further on another page, tracing a finger near the screen. “I see his name associated with Ox Bow Management in Rhode Island. Some sort of hedge fund. Maybe he works there?”

India tapped tabs until she got the picture of Baron again. Angel stared and tried not to give away how familiar she was with the gorgeous man in the photo. His charm, his height, his menace, the things he’d done to her, the way he’d made her shriek and wail when he brought her to orgasm . . . How she’d seen him revealed . . . She began to chew the inside of her cheek again. She said, “I swear that’s the guy.”

“Look at Grace Chen, good for her,” India said. “Guy’s probably worth a hundred mil, I bet you. Why the hell is she a professor? . . .”

“Beats me,” Angel said, and then felt strangely exposed, India’s iPad a sudden window into Angel’s secret perversion. She reached over, pulled the

top of the iPad so it flopped over onto India's stomach. They sat and looked at the ceiling for a moment longer. India said, "Can you do me a favor?"

"Maybe."

"Will you open that fucking box on the windowsill? I hate looking at it. It's driving me crazy. I want to know what's in it more than you do at this point."

"Really?" She sighed, moaned.

"Open it, open it, open it," India chanted, taunting her.

"Fine," she said, "can you get out of the way?"

India put a foot on the floor, pivoted, and fell onto her own bed. She lay back on her elbows and waited as Angel rose, went to the windowsill and hefted the small box wrapped with ribbon sitting on her windowsill in some unexpected November sunshine.

She untied the ribbon, peeled back the paper with her nails without tearing it.

It was a small square box with a lid. Robin's egg blue, gold print across the top. Berkman's. The jeweler in the town of Hager Hill, Illinois, where she and Brian grew up.

Box's lid in her clawed fingers, she pulled it up with a small flatulent sound, holding her breath.

At least it wasn't a ring.

She plucked from the box a chain of gold, her name and Brian's name, *Brian & Angel Forever*, on a small gold flag. A bracelet. A manacle. *Put this around your wrist, and your Brian's . . .* Manacled, like Baron had

manacled Kelly to the table in the mansion's conservatory. She gnawed at the inside corner of her mouth with her canines.

India said, "What is it?"

She pushed her pointed fingers in the loop of gold chain, raised her hand and let the bracelet fall around her wrist. It was too loose. Maybe it could be tightened. Tightened, tightened, tightened until she couldn't move . . .

"Gold bracelet."

India said, "Brian's playing for keeps."

"Brian is playing for keeps," she repeated dully.

"At least now you can tell him you opened it. What are you going to say?"

"I don't even know yet. I should call him." She flopped her hand downward, shook her wrist until Brian's bracelet fell back into the box whence it came. She returned the lid, put it in the drawer of her nightstand and closed it.

"You want me to go?" India asked. "I can get us coffees. Give you fifteen minutes . . ."

She nodded, picked up her phone and sat heavily on her bed. India stood, walked herself between Angel's knees and held her shoulders. "Be strong," she said and kissed Angel's hairline.

Things had changed last night. Not just the discovery of a dark facet of her virgin sexuality. India's shift closer to her this morning maybe surfing on something imperceptible—a gem within Angel polished last night now winking back, reflecting light shone at it, sending signals to the outer world there was life within . . .

India opened their dorm room door to the cacophony of Saturday mornings in Rothschild Hall, everybody up and roaming, waved, closed the door quietly.

She leaned forward with elbows on her knees and stared at her phone's black face for a long long time. Then she brought it to life and dialed.

The phone picked up on the second ring. Professor Chen said hello.

“Hi, hello, it’s me . . . uh, Angel.”

“I know, Angel—how are you this morning?”

“I’m fine, I . . . I was thinking . . .”

“And?”

“I think I’d like to go to Boston with you next weekend.”

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